Nityananda Prabhu

Нитьянанда Прабху · @nityananda

The Brother of Gaura

When the Son of Nanda came into the age of Kali as Sri Chaitanya, His elder brother came with Him. Krishnadasa Kaviraja says it simply:

“Now the son of Nanda Maharaja is Sri Chaitanya, and Baladeva is the brother of Sri Chaitanya, Nityananda.” (CC, Adi 17.295)

As in the Dvapara-yuga Baladeva appeared as the elder brother of Krishna, so in the Kali-yuga, in the form of Nityananda, He became the elder brother of Sri Gaurahari. Narottama Dasa sings the same: the son of the king of Vraja became the son of Shachi, and Balarama became Nitai. Lochana Dasa tells in the “Chaitanya-mangala” that even before the Lord's descent Narada came to Shvetadvipa and beheld there the lilas of Balarama — the Lord in the form of service; and then His eternal companions descended together with the Lord: Balarama as Nityananda, Shiva as Advaita, and all the rest.

The “Charitamrita” opens its account of Him with the same words — and at once confesses that His glory cannot be exhausted:

“Sri Chaitanya is Krishna Himself, and Nityananda is Balarama. Sri Nityananda fulfils all the desires of Sri Chaitanya.” (CC, Adi 5.156)

“The ocean of Sri Nityananda's glory has no bounds or limits. By His mercy I have been able to touch only a single drop of His greatness.” (CC, Adi 5.157)

Even the thousand-mouthed Ananta could not exhaust that ocean in all eternity; and Vrindavana Dasa adds that by Nityananda's mercy the whole world sings of Chaitanya to this day (CB, Antya 5.220). At the very beginning of the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Adi 1.16–19) He is praised as Haladhara — the bearer of the plough, vast of body, imperturbable and yet intoxicated by the nectar of Chaitanyachandra's glory; whoever hears of His deeds is taken under the special protection of Sri Krishna Chaitanya Himself, Shiva and Parvati are pleased with him, and Sarasvati appears upon his tongue.

Vrindavana Dasa himself does not undertake to settle what his Lord should be called. Some, he says, see in Him Balarama Himself, others the abode of love for Sri Chaitanya; ascetic, devotee or sage — whatever He may be to Chaitanya, may His feet be fixed in the hearts of all. For the “Bhagavata,” Nityananda is the first of Sri Chaitanya's devotees, His best and greatest beloved, and Krishna Chaitanya Himself is His life and soul. Opening the chapter on His childhood and wanderings, Vrindavana Dasa glorifies together Krishna Chaitanya, Nityananda the friend of the helpless, Advaita, and Vishvambhara, the refuge of Srivasa and Gadadhara; and elsewhere he says that the Lord descended surrounded by His eternal companions — Nityananda, Advaita, Gadadhara and all the pure devotees. How Baladeva manifests Himself as Sankarshana and the purusha-avataras, and what His form as a devotee in the Pancha-tattva means, will be told further on.

His names are past counting. Vrindavana Dasa, “the Vyasa of Sri Chaitanya's lilas,” calls Him Nityananda Avadhuta, Nityananda-chandra, Nityananda-rama and Nityananda-raya, Nityananda-svarupa and Nityananda-svarupa-gosani, Nityananda Bhagavan and Nityananda Mahaprabhu, Prabhuvara, Mahavira, Mahabali, Mahamati, Mahashaya, Mahamaheshvara, Nityananda-simha, Nityananda-mahamalla and Mahamalla-raya, Nitai-chand, Nitai Thakura, Ishvara Nitai, Vishvambhara and Gaudeshvara, “the lord of Gauda”; to him He is Avadhuta-chandra,

Avadhutavara, Avadhutamani, Avadhuta-mahabala, Avadhuta-mahashaya, Avadhuta-raya and Avadhuta-simha, “the abode of Sri Chaitanya's great love,” “the father of sankirtana,” “the guardian of the dharma of the age,” “the delight of the world,” “the one most dear to Sri Chaitanya,” “the beloved form of Chaitanya-chandra”[1]. The name “Mahamalla-raya” is explained as “the commander-in-chief of the army of sankirtana.” He is also called Ananta, the original Lord, the moonlike Nityananda and the friend of the helpless. Vaishnavas say that particular joy and blessing come from the very names with which Vrindavana Dasa glorified Him, for in chanting the names of Nityananda one reveals the glory of Sri Chaitanya.

Most often He is called an avadhuta. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati, following Shridhara Svami (on the “Bhagavatam” 3.1.19), explains the word thus: one who takes no care of the body (Anubhashya on CC, Adi 5.161); an avadhuta has cast off worldly feelings and duties and is bound by no conventions, not even the rules of varnashrama. Nityananda lives in the world of krishna-prema, in unbroken divine ecstasy, and gives no thought to adorning the body — that is why He is the Avadhuta. In His wanderings, too, He went about in the guise of an avadhuta.

But above all He is mercy. Krishnadasa Kaviraja, speaking of Him, suddenly turns to himself:

“I am more sinful than Jagai and Madhai and lower than a wretched worm in dung.” (CC, Adi 5.205)

“Who in all the world but Sri Nityananda could have poured out His mercy on such a sinner as I am?” (CC, Adi 5.207)

“Sri Nityananda is intoxicated with loving frenzy. He is the embodiment of supreme mercy and compassion, and so He makes no distinction between good and bad.” (CC, Adi 5.208)

It was He, Kaviraja goes on, who brought him to Vrindavana and gave him shelter at the feet of Sri Rupa (Adi 5.209–210). For the most fallen, who have no merit at all, hope in Nityananda's feet is the crown of piety; and even the pain of knowing one's own unworthiness, and the longing for His shelter, are already His mercy. He alone drags the sinner out “by the hair,” leads him out of the fortress of Mahamaya and gives him the right to enter the market of the holy name, Vrindavana, and the service of the Divine Couple. Gaura is merciful to those who belong to Nityananda — and so great devotees pray to the Vaishnavas for Nityananda's mercy. Vrindavana Dasa says the same at the beginning of his book:

“One who wishes to cross the ocean of material existence and plunge into the ocean of devotional service must devote himself to the worship of Sri Nityananda.” (CB, Adi 1.77)

“At the feet of the Vaishnavas I pray for one desire alone: to serve, birth after birth, the lotus feet of my Gurudeva, Sri Balarama!” (CB, Adi 1.78)

Appearance in Ekachakra

Nityananda appeared before Mahaprabhu — on the thirteenth lunar day of the bright fortnight of the month of Magha, Maghi shukla-trayodashi. The “Chaitanya-bhagavata” sets these two days side by side:

“Gaurachandra appeared on the night of the full moon of the month of Phalguna, and Lord Nityananda appeared in the month of Magha on the thirteenth day of the waxing moon.” (CB, Adi 3.45)

“If a person honours these two festivals, he will attain devotion to Lord Krishna and cut the bonds of material slavery.” (CB, Adi 3.47)

Therefore this tithi, like Phalguni-purnima, the day of Gaurasundara's appearance, brings blessing to the whole world and is worthy of the highest honour.

The place of His appearance was the village of Ekachakra, or Ekachaka, in Rarh — Radha-desha, in the land of Gauda. Where it once stood are now Birchandrapur, Garbhavasa and other villages, about four kroshas east of Mallarpur station on the loop line of the East Indian Railway. The place was later named Birchandrapur in honour of Nityananda's son, Sri Birachandra (Virabhadra) Prabhu. The “Charitamrita” names Rarh as the birthplace of more than Nityananda alone:

“Whereas Nityananda Prabhu, Gangadasa Pandita, Murari Gupta and Mukunda were born in Radha-desha.” (CC, Adi 13.61)[2]

His father was Hadai Pandita (or Harai Pandita); he was also known as Hadai, or Hado, Ojha — Hado Upadhyaya: “ojha,” or “jha,” is a corruption of “upadhyaya,” the family title of Maithila brahmanas. Hadai came of a Maithila brahmana family and was a highly renounced Vaishnava. His mother, Padmavati-devi, was wholly devoted to the service of Hari; herself a Vaishnava shakti, she tirelessly served Vaishnavas and guests. According to the “Bhakti-ratnakara,” an old brahmana of Shaligrama told Surya Dasa that Harai Pandita and Padmavati of Ekachakra were, in Krishna's lila, Vasudeva and Rohini, and Balarama appeared as their son Nityananda. Coming into their family, He granted them service to Himself in parental love — vatsalya-rasa. Vrindavana Dasa says that He rose like the moon from the ocean of the womb of Padmavati, wife of Hadai Ojha, and dispelled the darkness over Rarh. One of the biographies calls Vishvarupa, Mahaprabhu's elder brother, Nityananda's “other Self.”

With His coming every kind of good fortune arrived in Radha-desha: famine, poverty and misfortune vanished. From infancy He was restrained and very intelligent, endowed with every virtue, and His beauty eclipsed millions of Kamadevas.

Not far from Ekachaka resides Shiva Maudeshvara (Maureshvara). Nityananda worshipped him to show an example of service to a Vaishnava: without service to the Vaishnava there is no mercy of Vishnu. It is said that Hadai Pandita too worshipped Shiva — Bhandishvara, the best of Vaishnavas.

On the day Gaurachandra appeared in Navadvipa-Mayapur, Nityananda in Ekachakra gave a thunderous cry of joy, and the sound filled the universe. People explained it in different ways: some thought lightning had struck, others that the voice of God had thundered, still others that it was an omen of disaster; many understood that a divine power was at work, and someone said, “The lord of Gauda has spoken in a voice of thunder.” But Krishna's yogamaya covered everyone, and no one recognised in the boy Who He was.

Bankim-raya and the Memorial Places of Ekachakra

In Ekachakra resides the Deity of Krishna — Sri Bankim-raya (Bankima-deva), installed by Nityananda, together with Srimati Radha. Tradition tells that Bankim-raya was floating on the waters of the Yamuna at Kadambakhandi ghat, east of the temple, and Nityananda lifted Him from the water and installed Him. Srimati appeared at the hamlet of Bhaddarpur, about half a mile west of Birchandrapur. The local sevaites say that Nityananda entered into Bankim-raya, and therefore Sri Jahnava-mata, Nityananda's shakti, was later installed at His right. The sevaites of Birchandrapur themselves are a collateral branch of the line of Gopijana-vallabha.

There is also a place in Ekachakra called Vishramtala: according to local tradition, here the boy Nityananda played the lilas of Krishna and Rama with His friends. These places were honoured later as well. According to the “Bhakti-ratnakara,” when Jahnava visited Ekachakra on her way back from Vraja, she was shown the places of His childhood lilas; she spent the night in His parents' deserted house and passed the whole night in kirtana. Narottama came here too; an old brahmana showed him the places of the lilas, and Narottama, remembering the names of Hadai Pandita and Padmavati-devi, fell senseless.

Childhood: the Lilas of Krishna, Rama and Vamana

Concealing His divinity, the boy Nityananda played with the children not at ordinary games but at the lilas of Krishna, Rama and other avataras; and Krishna was always at the centre of every game. His friends never left Him and did not go home, playing day and night, and the parents did not worry — they loved Him with all their hearts and embraced Him tenderly. Everyone wondered — Hadai and Padmavati first of all — how the child knew Krishna's deeds and why, instead of ordinary pastimes, He enacted the lilas of the incarnations of Vishnu.

It all began with an “assembly of the gods.” One boy played the Earth presenting the gods' petition to Vishnu; all went with the “Earth” to the riverbank and prayed to Kshirodakashayi Vishnu, and a hidden boy announced loudly, “Soon I shall be born in the cowherd village of Mathura”[3]. Then they enacted the wedding of Vasudeva and Devaki, Krishna's appearance at midnight in “Kamsa's prison” — a play-hut — the carrying of the infant to the cowherd settlement, and His exchange for yogamaya.

Then came the lilas of Vraja. One boy dressed as Putana, another “sucked” her breast; they broke a cart of reeds; they stole milk and yoghurt from the house of the local milkman; they made snakes of leaves, and a boy lay motionless in the pond while Nityananda “woke” him — that was how they played Kaliya; in a palm grove they “slew” Dhenuka and ate the tala fruits; they overcame toy demons — Baka, Agha, Vatsa; at evening they returned from the pasture blowing buffalo horns. They lifted Govardhana, built a Vrindavana, stole the gopis' garments, went to the wives of the sacrificial brahmanas. A bearded boy-“Narada” gave secret counsel to Kamsa, and a boy-“Akrura” carried Krishna and Balarama away — and then Nityananda, overwhelmed by the feelings of the gopis, wept in separation from Krishna, and tears streamed from His eyes before the children.

They built Mathura too: some were garland-sellers, others those who wore the garlands; Nityananda dressed one boy as Kubja and accepted fragrant paste from her; with a thunderous crack He broke the bow; He slew the elephant Kuvalayapida and the wrestlers Chanura and Mushtika, seized “Kamsa” by the hair and, having “killed” him, danced merrily with the children, while the people of Ekachakra laughed with delight. They played the Vamana-lila as well: a boy-“Bali” gave away the three worlds, an old boy-“Shukracharya” forbade the gift, and “Vamana,” having accepted the alms, placed His foot on “Bali's” head. By the will of Vishnu's yogamaya no one understood that these games were no childish play.

He loved the Ramayana no less. Children playing monkeys built a bridge across the ocean: Nityananda cut branches and threw them into the water as though they were huge trees, to cries of “Jaya Rama! Jaya Raghunatha!” As Lakshmana He strode in anger, bow in hand, to Sugriva's palace: “Worthless monkey! My Lord Rama grieves on Mount Malyavan, and you make merry with women. If you want to live, hurry to Rama with help!” As Lakshmana He also threatened Parashurama[4]. Meeting five “monkeys” in the forest, “Lakshmana” asked who they were, calling Himself a servant of Raghunatha; they begged Him to lead them to Rama, for they feared Bali, and He embraced them, led them to “Rama” and fell prostrate. “Lakshmana” was now defeated by Indrajit, now slew him; a boy-“Vibhishana” He brought to Rama and crowned king of Lanka.

Once a boy-“Ravana” threw a lotus flower at Him as though it were the shakti spear, and “Lakshmana” fell without sign of life. The children began to weep; the parents ran up and, finding no life in their son, themselves fell senseless; the whole village gathered. Someone recalled an actor who had played Dasharatha and died on the stage on hearing of Rama's exile; but another said, “It is only a part: Hanuman will bring the medicine, and He will come round.” Nityananda had taught the children beforehand: when He fell, they were to surround Him and weep, then send “Hanuman,” and life would return as soon as the medicine was held to His nose; but in their fright the children forgot the instruction

— and remembered it only after the onlooker's words.

And “Hanuman” set out — every word he spoke had been taught him by Nityananda. A “sage” with fruits and roots invited him to stay — Hanuman hurried on; a “crocodile” in a pond seized his feet — and was defeated; a “rakshasa” threatened to swallow him — and after a fight was defeated too; the “gandharvas” on Mount Gandhamadana were also overcome, and Hanuman brought the mountain on his head. A boy-physician — Sushena, the monkeys' physician — held the herb vishalyakarani to “Lakshmana's” nose, and “Lakshmana” rose, and the parents came to themselves. Everyone laughed; Hadai Pandita embraced his son, and people asked, “Child, how do You know all this?” — and He answered, smiling, “These are all My lilas.”[5]

In early childhood His body was tender and fair; no one wanted to let Him out of their arms, and people loved Him more than their own sons, while from infancy nothing was dear to Him but Krishna's lila. Vrindavana Dasa sees in Him the Supreme Lord Himself, though the children and His kin did not understand it; he bows a hundred times at the feet of the boys who played with Him, for His lilas are revealed only by His own mercy.

To Hadai and Padmavati He was the eldest son[6] — and the one apple of their eye, their very life: they could not bear to be without Him even for a little while. Hadai Pandita tilled the land, served as a priest, went away on business — and thought of Nityananda all the time. The “Chaitanya-bhagavata” says:

“Hadai Pandita would not let Nityananda go a single step from him. One might have thought that Hadai Pandita was the body and Nityananda his soul.” (CB, Madhya 3.75)

He never let his son out of his sight and embraced Him endlessly, and it seemed as if the child's tender body melted into his father's (CB, Madhya 3.73–74). So, in play, the twelve years of His life at home went by.

The Sannyasi at the Door

When Nityananda turned twelve, a wandering Vaishnava sannyasi came to Ekachakra. Hadai recognised in him a pure Vaishnava, invited him for bhiksha and talked with him all night about Krishna. In the morning the guest asked for “alms”: to give him for a time the eldest son, marked with auspicious signs, so that on pilgrimage the boy might cook offerings for the Lord — for a sannyasi does not kindle a fire. He promised to guard Him more than his own life and to show Him all the holy places. The biographies have not preserved this sannyasi's name[7].

Hadai was shaken — not because he was unwilling to give, but at the very thought that his son would pass out of his sight. Yet he remembered the mahajanas of former times: so had Dasharatha given Rama to Vishvamitra. Praying to Krishna for protection in this trial of dharma (dharma-sankata), he told everything to his wife, and Padmavati answered without a shadow of hesitation, “To follow your will is my dharma.” With his wife's joyful consent Hadai entrusted his son to the sannyasi, and Nityananda went with him — to display the lila of serving a Vaishnava and purifying the holy places.

Hadai and Padmavati are the model of a Vaishnava householder: to serve the Vaishnava, giving him one's whole life — for, as the “Bhagavatam” teaches, one should always do good: with one's life, wealth, mind and words. A gift into which life is put is the highest gift; a gift without it is only a ritual. We readily praise the sacrifices of others, while we ourselves draw back or deceive ourselves; millions of sannyasis long for the dust from the feet of such grihasthas. Nor was Hadai's parental love a worldly attachment to a son: worldly attachment is only its defective reflection, while a drop of such love makes even the happiness of liberation insignificant. The partings of great souls the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” explains by the examples of Kapila, who left his mother Devahuti, of Shukadeva, who went away from Vyasa, and of Gaura Himself, who left Shachi:

“In truth none of these examples of renunciation is a forsaking of one's obligations. At their root lies the attainment of the highest good, but only great souls can understand this.” (CB, Madhya 3.104)

The parting was hard for Hado Upadhyaya: he nearly lost his mind, seemed to people to be stunned, and for three months neither ate nor drank. He remained alive — but from then on was forever “mad for Nityananda.”

Twenty Years of Wandering

So at twelve Nityananda set out for the holy places — to purify them of the sins left there by pilgrims. In the guise of a pilgrim He went through the north and south of India, sanctified places that had never been holy before, and only then came to Sri Chaitanya in Navadvipa. The “Chaitanya-bhagavata” gives the periods:

“Thus Lord Nityananda spent twelve years in the house of His parents. Then He set out on pilgrimage to the holy places.” (CB, Adi 9.100)

“For the next twenty years He travelled through the holy places, and then He joined Lord Chaitanya.” (CB, Adi 9.101)[8]

The old brahmana of Shaligrama, according to the “Bhakti-ratnakara,” told Surya Dasa: Nitai went to all the holy places, performed many austerities and became a great scholar, and then He came to Navadvipa and became Chaitanya's dearest companion.

Vrindavana Dasa describes His route in order[9]. From Vakreshvara He went alone to the forest of Vaidyanatha, from there to Gaya, then to Kashi, where the Ganga flows northward — there He bathed and drank her water with insatiable thirst; in the month of Magha He took the morning bath at Prayaga. Then He came to Mathura, the place of His former birth: He bathed in the Yamuna at Vishrama-ghata and in ecstasy circled Govardhana and all twelve forests of Vrindavana. In Gokula, in the house of Nanda Maharaja, He sat and wept with overflowing feeling and bowed down to Madana-Gopala. In Hastinapura, the abode of the Pandavas, He wept at the sight of the place of great devotees — the people there, who knew nothing of devotion, could not understand it; and seeing the glory of Balarama in Hastinapura, He bowed and cried out, “Save Me, Haladhara!”

In Dvaraka He bathed joyfully in the sea; He was at Siddhapura, the abode of Kapila; at Matsya-tirtha, at a great festival, He distributed much cooked rice; at Shiva-Kanchi and Vishnu-Kanchi He laughed to see the bitter enmity of the devotees of Vishnu and of Shiva. He passed through Kurukshetra, Prithudaka, Bindu-sarovara, Prabhasa, Sudarshana-tirtha, Trita-kupa, Vishala, Brahma-tirtha, Chakra-tirtha, Pratisrota, the ancient, western Sarasvati and Naimisharanya. In Ayodhya He wept much at Sri Rama's birthplace; in the kingdom of Guha the chandala, Shringaverapura, remembering his devotion, He lay unconscious for three days; in all the forests where Rama had stayed He rolled on the ground in the agony of separation.

He bathed in the Sarayu, was at the Kaushiki and at the hermitage of the sage Pulastya, bathed in the Gomati, the Gandaki and the Shona; on the summit of Mount Mahendra He bowed down to Parashurama; He was at Haridvara, where the Ganga descends to earth, at Pampa, Bhimarathi, Sapta-Godavari, and at the tirthas of the Venva and the Vipasha. He saw Karttikeya and came to Mount Shri (Shri-shaila), where Shiva and Parvati live in the form of a brahmana and his wife. Both recognised in the avadhuta wayfarer their own Deity; Parvati cooked prasada for Him with her own hands, and they fed Him with reverence, while He smiled and bowed to them. What they spoke of in secret, only Krishna knows.

In the land of Dravida He visited Venkatanatha, Kamakoshti-puri, Kanchi, the river Kaveri and Srirangam, where He stayed for some time, Hari-kshetra, Mount Rishabha, Southern Mathura (Madurai), the Kritamala and the Tamraparni, and then Uttara-Yamuna and the hermitage of Agastya on Mount Malaya; everywhere the local people received Him gladly. At Badarikashrama He lived for some time in complete solitude, in the hermitage of the rishi Nara-Narayana; and at the hermitage of Vyasa, Shamyaprasa, Vyasa himself recognised Balarama in Him, appeared before Him and received his guest, and the Lord bowed down to Srila Vyasadeva. He also entered a monastery of Buddhists: He put questions to them, but no one could answer; then, angered, He struck them on the head with His foot — the Buddhists ran off laughing, and He calmly went on His way.

Next came Kanyakumari, where He had darshana of Durga-devi, the Southern Sea, Sri Ananta (Anantapura), the pond of the five apsaras (Pancha-apsara), the temple of Shiva at Gokarna; He went from door to door through Kerala and Trigarta, saw Arya-Dvaipayani — the goddess Parvati on an island near Gokarna, was at the Nirvindhya, the Payasvini and the Tapti, at the Reva, in the city of Mahishmati and at Malla-tirtha, and through Shurparaka went on to the west. In all His wanderings He feared nothing and no one; constantly absorbed in Krishna, He had no control over His body; He now laughed, now wept — who can fathom His moods?

Meeting Madhavendra Puri

In the west of India[10] Nityananda chanced to meet Madhavendra Puri. He wandered freely with disciples full of krishna-prema; he knew no food but the taste of Krishna's qualities, and his body was the place of Krishna's lilas; and the highest praise of his love is that the great Advaita Acharya was his disciple. Mahaprabhu Himself more than once called Madhavendra the original teacher of pure devotion. With him were Ishvara Puri, Brahmananda Puri and other disciples.

Seeing each other, both fainted from love and lay motionless, while Ishvara Puri and Madhavendra's other disciples wept. Coming to, they embraced and wept, rolled on the ground and roared with joy; tears flowed in streams, their bodies trembled, their hair stood on end — all eight spiritual transformations appeared in them, for Chaitanya Mahaprabhu Himself was dancing in their hearts. Nityananda said:

“Lord Nityananda said: ‘I have gone round many holy places, but today I have reached the goal of My pilgrimage. Today I have seen the lotus feet of Madhavendra Puri. Seeing his exalted love, I have attained the perfection of life.’” (CB, Adi 9.166–167)

And Madhavendra embraced Nityananda, bathed Him in tears, took Him on his lap and pressed Him to his breast; from love he could not utter a word and would not let Him go. Such love, he said, he had met nowhere[11], and where it is, there for him are all the holy places; Krishna was merciful to him, since He had sent such a companion:

“I have met Nityananda, and therefore I know that Krishna has granted me His mercy.” (CB, Adi 9.183)

“The place where one can have the company of Nityananda is the holiest and wholly transcendental.” (CB, Adi 9.184)

“If a person hears the name of Nityananda, he will certainly attain the lotus feet of Lord Krishnachandra.” (CB, Adi 9.185)

For him Nityananda's company contained in itself all the tirthas and Vaikuntha itself; and whoever bears even a little dislike for Nityananda will not be dear to Krishna, however much of a devotee he may seem. Day and night Madhavendra glorified Nityananda and served Him with love[12].

Ishvara Puri, Brahmananda Puri and all Madhavendra's disciples felt a natural, irresistible love for Nityananda; Ishvara Puri understood how infinitely dear He was to his guru. Before, meeting many renunciants — karmis, jnanis, yogis, ascetics and keepers of vows, each with desires of his own — Madhavendra and his disciples had found in them no trace of love for Krishna and had gone off sorrowfully into the forests; the meeting with Nityananda dispelled that sorrow.

For a few days[13] they wandered together — from forest to forest, as if searching for Krishna — and spoke of His lilas, while the brotherhood of disciples sang the name of Hari without pause. Madhavendra, at the sight of a dark cloud, remembered Krishna and fell senseless — his love in separation is beyond description; day and night, intoxicated with love, both laughed, wept and, beside themselves, cried, "Haya! Haya!"[14] And Nityananda, intoxicated with the nectar of Govinda's sweetness, reeled, stumbled, fell, laughed aloud and thundered. Their talks of Krishna were confidential, and only Krishna could understand them; day and night lost all meaning for them:

"Nityananda and Madhavendra Puri noticed neither day nor night — so deep was their absorption in the moods of ecstatic love. The few days they spent together flew by for them like a single moment." (CB, Adi 9.179)

At last they parted: Nityananda went to Setubandha, Rama's bridge, and Madhavendra to the Sarayu. Both were so absorbed in Krishna that they did not remember their bodies — only so could they bear the agony of separation. Whoever hears with faith of Nityananda and Madhavendra, says Vrindavana Dasa — of His pilgrimage and of their meeting — obtains the treasure of love for Krishna.

Whether Nityananda was Madhavendra's disciple is a matter on which opinions differ[15]. One thing is clear: although He is the teacher of the world's teachers and the crown of acharyas, He honoured Madhavendra as guru for the sake of example and never treated him otherwise. According to the "Bhakti-ratnakara," Madhavendra dealt with Nityananda as a friend and equal, and Nitai with him as with an elder. Nityananda was pleased to accept Madhavendra as guru for the instruction of people; and to regard Him as Madhavendra's disciple or as his godbrother is in essence one and the same: honour to a godbrother is not different from honour to the guru.

Nilachala, Gangasagara and the Waiting in Vrindavana

Having parted from Madhavendra, Nityananda bathed at Dhanus-tirtha, visited Rameshvaram, Vijayanagara, Mayapuri (Haridvara), Avanti, the Godavari, the abode of Jiyur-Nrisimhadeva (Simhachala), Tirumala, the shrine of Kurmanatha, and came to Purushottama. As soon as He entered the city of Sri Jagannatha, the moon of Nilachala, He saw the flag above the temple and fell senseless[16]; at darshana He saw Jagannatha in four forms (chaturvyuha), with all His servants, and again and again lost and regained consciousness: He was shaken with trembling, bathed in perspiration and tears, and gave thunderous cries. After a few days in Nilachala He visited Gangasagara, where the Ganga flows into the ocean. Vrindavana Dasa confesses that he has described only a small part of His wanderings — and that only by His mercy.

Having gone round the holy places, Nityananda came again to Mathura and settled in Vrindavana:

"He dwelt in Vrindavana and was so absorbed in thoughts of Krishna that He could not tell day from night." (CB, Adi 9.205)

"He ate nothing, and only now and then drank a little milk if it was offered to Him." (CB, Adi 9.206)

Meanwhile in Navadvipa Gaurasundara was already living[17] — and grieved, not seeing Nityananda, His "second body." Nityananda, for His part, thought: "Sri Gaurachandra is in Navadvipa, but His glory is still hidden; as soon as the Lord wishes to reveal His divinity, I shall go at once to Navadvipa to serve

Him.” So He did not go to Navadvipa and did not leave Mathura, but kept playing with children in the waters of the Yamuna and in the dust of Vrindavana, wandering through Vrindavana and the holy places until Sri Chaitanya revealed Himself:

“Lord Nityananda is all-powerful, but at that time He did not bestow devotional service to the Lord on people. Only after Lord Gaurachandra had revealed His divine greatness and ordered Him to preach did Lord Nityananda begin His preaching. The servants and companions of the Lord do nothing without receiving the Lord's instruction. Yet this in no way diminishes their glory.” (CB, Adi 9.211)

Possessed of all power, He concealed His lila of bestowing prema-bhakti and waited for Gaurachandra to reveal the greatness of sankirtana and give the order. The thought “to do nothing without the will of Sri Chaitanya” does not diminish but exalts service to the Lord: even Ananta, Brahma, Shiva and all the gods do nothing without His sanction, and the destroyers, rulers and maintainers of the universe carry out their duties only by His command. And on those who do not like to hear the glory of Nityananda the Vaishnavas do not even cast a glance.

Vrindavana Dasa closes the chapter on Nityananda's childhood and wanderings with praise and prayer. Nityananda delivered the whole world; He is the incomparable ocean of mercy; only by His mercy has the author himself grasped the truth about Sri Chaitanya, only through Him has Mahaprabhu's greatness been proclaimed, and only wicked godless men revile Him. All three worlds bear witness that the treasure of love for God was obtained by Nityananda's mercy. His tongue keeps the praise of Sri Chaitanya, and day and night He speaks only of Chaitanya; by serving Him one obtains devotion to Chaitanya, and attachment to Nityananda is itself a gift of Mahaprabhu's mercy. For one who knows Nityananda there is no danger anywhere; and whoever wishes to cross the darkness of this world and plunge into the ocean of devotion, let him serve Him. Mahaprabhu, says Vrindavana Dasa, “gave us Nityananda — and took Him away.”

He also warns against one mistake. Some followers of Sri Chaitanya speak of Nityananda in a way that seems like blame but is in fact praise; these Vaishnavas are pure of heart, and their apparent quarrel is only lila (one translation of the chapter explains that Vaishnavas such as Advaita Acharya are meant). But whoever takes the side of one and reviles the other will perish; and whoever follows Nityananda without seeking faults in Him will attain the shelter of Sri Gaurachandra. And Vrindavana Dasa prays: to see Sri Chaitanya and Nityananda among the devotees; that Nityananda be his eternal master; that, keeping faith with Nityananda, he may serve the feet of Gaurachandra and, birth after birth, study the “Srimad-Bhagavatam” at Nityananda's feet — for without Mahaprabhu's consent no one attains the feet of Nityananda.

Arrival in Navadvipa

How Nityananda learned that the Lord had revealed Himself the biographies tell differently[18]. Wandering through India in the mood of separation and searching for Krishna, He came to Vrindavana — and here it was revealed to His heart that Krishna had already appeared in Navadvipa-Mayapur as Gaura Hari, the son of Shachi. He hastened from Mathura to Mayapur-Navadvipa, which is not different from Mathura, and arrived there after the Lord had returned from Gaya. He stayed in the house of the mahabhagavata Nandana Acharya[19] and lived there incognito; Nandana, seeing a radiant avadhuta with arms reaching to His knees, fed Him with reverence and kept Him in his home, and, given the chance to serve Him, considered his life fulfilled. At different times Mahaprabhu, Nityananda and Advaita all took refuge in Nandana's house.

The all-knowing Mahaprabhu knew of His coming and hinted to the Vaishnavas that in two or three days a great personage would arrive. He learned of it in a dream. To His door came the chariot of

Baladeva with its palm-tree banner (tala-dhvaja); in it sat a huge man with an enormous pole — a club or a plough — on his shoulder[20], in blue garments, with a cane kamandalu in his left hand. A resident of Vraja, he kept asking in Vraja-buli, “Is this the house of Nimai Pandita?” — and when asked who he was, answered with a smile, “I am your brother; tomorrow we shall know each other.” And Mahaprabhu felt as though He too were that very one. Telling the dream, Gaura entered the mood of Baladeva, roared and began to demand “wine”; Srivasa replied that the wine of Hari-rasa is with Him alone, and only he to whom He gives it will receive it[21]. Returning to external consciousness, Gaura Himself explained the meaning of the dream to the Vaishnavas: someone truly great had come to Navadvipa[22].

Mahaprabhu announced the guest's coming to the devotees and sent Srivasa and Haridasa to look for Him. For three praharas they searched the town — the houses of Vaishnavas, sannyasis, householders, even of the godless; only the villages outside Navadvipa they did not search — and did not find Him. Gaura smiled and hinted: only one to whom Sri Chaitanya Himself reveals Nityananda can recognise Him. And the Lord with His devotees went straight to the house of Nandana Acharya[23].

There they saw One who shone like a million suns. According to the “Bhakti-ratnakara,” He was sitting in meditation, and all gazed on His incomparable beauty; and the Two of Them looked long and steadily at each other. Seeing that Nityananda remained silent, Mahaprabhu told Srivasa to recite the verse of the “Bhagavatam” about Krishna's entering Vrindavana:

“With an ornament of peacock feathers, in the form of the best of dancers, with karnikara flowers at His ears, in garments the colour of gold and with a vaijayanti garland, He filled the holes of the flute with the nectar of His lips and entered Vrindavana, made beautiful by His footprints, while His cowherd friends sang His glory.” (Bhag. 10.21.5)

On hearing the verse Nityananda fell senseless, and all eight spiritual transformations appeared in Him. The verse was recited again and again; coming to, Nityananda wept for joy, and the madness of love grew ever greater. His roar seemed to split the universe; He fell to the ground so that His bones seemed to break, and the Vaishnavas cried out in fear, “Krishna, protect Him!”; He rolled on the ground in tears, never taking His eyes from Gaura's face, danced, fell prostrate, leapt — and the Vaishnavas could not hold Him. Then Vishvambhara took Him on His lap and pressed Him to His breast, as brother to brother — and He grew calm, and all made the air ring with the name of Hari.

Mahaprabhu glorified Him before the devotees: “Today I have seen with My own eyes prema-bhakti-yoga — the essence of the four Vedas. You are the embodied wealth of love for Krishna. Whoever stays with You even for a moment, even for half a sesame seed of time, cannot be called wicked, even with millions of sins; worship of You gives the treasure of krishna-prema.” When Gaura asked where He had come from, Nityananda, like a child, told Him everything: He had seen all the places of Krishna's lilas, but had not seen Krishna Himself; great Vaishnavas had told Him that Krishna had gone to Gauda-desha, had lately been in Gaya and had come to Nadia; hearing that Krishna, the Saviour of the fallen, had appeared in Nadia with sankirtana, “this sinner” had come here. Gaura replied, “We are all fortunate — a great bhagavata has appeared here.”

The Vaishnavas each spoke in their own way of the two Lords. Murari: “These are Your affairs; we cannot understand them.” Srivasa: “What can we understand? They honour each other like Madhava and Shankara.” Gadadhara: “Well said; it is like Rama and Lakshmana”[24].

The Vyasa-puja in Srivasa's House

A few days later Mahaprabhu wished Nityananda to perform the Vyasa-puja. “Tomorrow is the full moon, the day of the Vyasa-puja,” said Gaura. “Where will You perform it?” Nityananda understood His intention, took Srivasa by the hand and led him forward: “In the house of this brahmana.” Srivasa

joyfully took the whole puja upon himself. At Mahaprabhu's bidding the sankirtana-adhivasa was held: Nitai and Gaura entered Srivasa's house-temple and had the outer door locked, so that only their own people could enter — and countless waves and signs of love appeared. That night Mahaprabhu revealed that Nityananda is Baladeva, and made it known that He Himself had descended for the sake of Advaita Acharya[25].

Gaura calmed Nityananda and went home for the night, but Nityananda stayed at Srivasa's — and in the night, with a roar, He broke His staff (danda) and kamandalu. In the morning Mahaprabhu learned of it from Ramai Pandita, Srivasa's brother; He came, took Nityananda to bathe in the Ganga, laid the danda in the river and told Him to perform the Vyasa-puja without delay.

The acharya of the Vyasa-puja was Srivasa. He placed in Nityananda's hand a garland of forest flowers of wonderful fragrance, so that He might offer it to Vyasadeva with a hymn. Nityananda answered aloud, “Yes, yes,” — but then only murmured something indistinct, holding the garland and looking about Him. Srivasa complained, “Your Shripada is not performing the Vyasa-puja!” Mahaprabhu came up and urged Him on — and the ever-independent Nityananda, seeing Him before Him, placed the garland around the neck of Mahaprabhu Himself. At once Mahaprabhu showed Him His six-armed form — with the club and plough of Balarama — and Nityananda fainted from love.

“Nityananda, be calm,” said Gaura. “The purpose of Your incarnation — the spreading of kirtana — is fulfilled. You are the keeper of the treasury of prema-bhakti: only if You give will people receive prema.” Later, explaining why the Lord once did not feel prema, Advaita would say, “You made Nityananda the keeper of the treasury of prema, and You deprived Srivasa and me of it and gave it away to everyone, even the low-born.” At the end Mahaprabhu declared the Vyasa-puja complete and told all to sing the name of Hari; Nitai and Gaura danced together, and Shachi secretly watched them both with a mother's love. Mahaprabhu took prasada from Srivasa and distributed it to all Himself, even to Srivasa's servants. So, together with Nityananda, Mahaprabhu began the lilas of sankirtana, and their centre became Srivasa's courtyard, Srivasa-angana; the Lord, Nityananda and Their companions were immersed in the ecstasy of kirtana.

In Srivasa's House and at Shachi's

Nityananda settled in Srivasa's house in Mayapur, and Malini-devi, Srivasa's wife, served Him like her own son. Once Gaura tested Srivasa: “It is not good to keep close company with Nityananda — neither His family nor His character is known. If you want to keep your caste, let Him go.” Srivasa smiled: “Do not test me. Nityananda is Your body, and in God there is no difference between the body and the One within it.” Even if Nityananda should drink wine and keep company with a Yavana woman, he said, even if He should ruin my caste, my wealth and my life — my faith will not waver (CB, Madhya 8.15–16)[26].

“Hearing these words from Srivasa's lips, the Lord sprang up, gave a loud triumphant cry and pressed Srivasa to His breast.” (CB, Madhya 8.17)

“‘O Srivasa Pandita, what are you saying? Where does such deep faith in Nityananda come from? You have recognised in Nityananda My closest companion. I am very pleased with you and wish to grant you a blessing.’” (CB, Madhya 8.18–19)

And the Lord blessed him without any request: there will be no want in his house even if Lakshmi Herself goes begging through the towns; even the cats and dogs in his house will gain firm devotion.

“‘I entrust Nityananda to you. Take care of all His needs.’” (CB, Madhya 8.22)[27]

Much later, when Srivasa's son died during kirtana, Mahaprabhu said to him, “From this day Nityananda and I are your sons; We shall never leave you; remember this — and you will know no grief for your son.” Chaitanya and Nityananda were in debt to Srivasa for his devotion and service: so the Lord becomes the debtor of His devotees.

Shachi had a dream: Gaura and Nitai are Kanai and Balai of Vraja Themselves; Nitai called her “mother” and asked for food. She invited Nitai and fed Him together with Nimai. The Lord would beg His mother to let Him invite Nitai and, having her consent, would go to call Him Himself. Ishana Thakura served Nityananda too, Chaitanya's “other Self”: before the meal at Shachi's he brought water to wash Their feet (CB, Madhya 8.59), and, as Srila Bhaktisiddhanta says, he gathered the rice Nityananda had scattered about the house and put things in order.

Nityananda lived in Navadvipa like a child. Once a crow carried off from Srivasa's house a pot of ghee meant for the worship of Vishnu; Malini, fearing her husband's anger, wept — and Nityananda told the crow to bring the pot back, and it returned it at once. Once, while Gaura was accepting Vishnupriya's service, Nityananda, without external consciousness, entered the courtyard of His house naked and answered questions at random; Mahaprabhu Himself clothed Him, while Shachi laughed at His childlike mood. Another time, naked and in the same childlike mood, He came to Gaura roaring, “My Lord Nimai Pandita!” — and Gaura, laughing, wrapped Him in the cloth from His own head, anointed Him with fragrances, put a garland on Him, seated Him and glorified Him. In the rainy season He swam fearlessly in the Ganga, full of crocodiles, and at times lay senseless from love for three or four days[28].

Gaura asked Nityananda for His kaupina, tore it to pieces and told the devotees to tie them on their heads, and at His bidding the devotees drank the water that had washed Nityananda's feet — charanamrita, hard to obtain even for Shiva and Brahma[29].

Murari Gupta, coming once to Srivasa's house, bowed first to Mahaprabhu and then to Nityananda; the Lord said that the order was wrong. That night Murari saw Nityananda in a dream as Haladhara — dressed as a wrestler, with plough and club in His hands, and the hoods of a great serpent swaying above His head; behind Him stood Vishvambhara, fanning Him. “Do you understand now, Murari?” the Lord smiled. “You must consider Me the younger.” From then on Murari bowed first to Nityananda[30]:

“Lotus-eyed Mahaprabhu sat on His seat, and at His right sat Nityananda, laughing.” (CB, Madhya 20.22)

“Murari first offered obeisances at the lotus-like feet of Nityananda, and then bowed down at the lotus-like feet of Vishvambhara.” (CB, Madhya 20.23)

So through Murari the Lord taught the truth about Himself and Nityananda, and the etiquette. Murari was a worshipper of Balarama, and Srila Bhaktisiddhanta explains: to worship the Supreme Lord without first bowing to the guru and jagad-guru, that is, to Nityananda, is a breach of etiquette.

Nityananda was among the companions gathered at Srivasa's and at Chandrashekhara's (CB, Madhya 8.110–112); and when Mahaprabhu drank water from Shridhara's leaky pitcher, Nityananda and Advaita led the kirtana in the courtyard (BR 12.3136–3141). Once, after He had been worshipped in Srivasa's house, Nityananda, the saviour of the fallen, visited Gangadasa Pandita — at that time He roamed Navadvipa in a childlike mood, playing with the boys. And in the drama at Chandrashekhara's house He played an old cowherd woman — Radha's maternal grandmother; and when Mahaprabhu danced as Adya-shakti, Nityananda fell senseless.

Advaita

Soon after the Vyasa-puja the Lord sent Ramai Pandita for Advaita with the message: the Lord of Goloka has appeared in Navadvipa, and Nityananda has come with Him. Advaita came to Navadvipa and hid in the house of Nandana Acharya. Mahaprabhu, understanding his intention, ascended the throne of Vishnu (vishnu-khattu) and revealed Advaita's thoughts to all; Nityananda, at the Lord's sign, held the royal umbrella over Him, while the Vaishnavas served and sang hymns. At a new bidding Ramai brought Advaita with his wife; Advaita bowed at Mahaprabhu's feet, and on seeing Nityananda glorified His greatness in many ways.

When Mahaprabhu threw Himself into the Ganga, Nityananda and Haridasa leapt in after Him and pulled Him out; to these two alone the Lord disclosed that He would hide in the house of Nandana Acharya. Before His sannyasa, Chaitanya and Nityananda would from time to time come to Advaita's house in Shantipur, hold a festival and sing kirtana all day and all night. Parameshvari Dasa sings in a pada (“Pada-kalpataru”): the Lord came to Advaita's temple and sat down; Nityananda and Advaita sat beside Him and jokingly discussed the festival; Sita Thakurani came in smiling, and the Lord had the Vaishnavas called and mridangas, karatalas, sandal paste and aguru made ready.

Once Mahaprabhu with Nityananda came unexpectedly to Shantipur, to Advaita, with whom Haridasa was living. The four of Them bathed in the Ganga; Advaita prostrated himself at Mahaprabhu's feet, and Haridasa at Advaita's, “like three links of the chain of a bridge,” — and Nityananda rejoiced. For several days They spoke of preaching the holy name, and then Mahaprabhu with Nityananda and Haridasa returned to Navadvipa. Another time Advaita began to extol knowledge above bhakti, and the Lord in anger dragged Him into the courtyard and began to punish Him. It was a lila: Advaita rejoiced at receiving punishment from the Lord (CB, Madhya 19.152). Advaita's wife, Sita, begged Him to spare the old brahmana, while Nityananda only smiled (CB, Madhya 19.135–138). Afterwards the Lord said to Nityananda, “If I showed agitation, forgive Me,” and They looked at each other and laughed; the Lord bathed in the Ganga with Nityananda, Advaita and Haridasa, and Sita served Them a meal.

Preaching the Name; Jagai and Madhai

Mahaprabhu made Nityananda and Haridasa the first preachers of the holy name:

“‘Listen, Nityananda! Listen, Haridasa! Go and reveal My instructions to the whole world. Go to every house and ask: “Chant the names of Krishna, worship Krishna and follow Krishna's instructions.” Speak of nothing else and ask for nothing more. Come at the end of the day and tell Me everything.’” (CB, Madhya 13.8–10)

The people of Navadvipa mocked such preaching, but the two, strong in Chaitanya's command, paid no attention.

In Navadvipa lived Jagai and Madhai — drunkards and robbers, great sinners born in a brahmana family; there was no vileness they had not committed — only offence to Vaishnavas had not touched them. Seeing their fall, Nityananda was especially merciful to them: His heart wept for them. He asked people about them and was fired with the wish to save them — then the whole world would know the glory of the Lord. He disclosed His plan to Haridasa, and Haridasa answered, “Whatever You desire is the Lord's desire.” Respectable people tried to dissuade Them, but They would not listen; They stood where the brothers could hear Them and loudly delivered Mahaprabhu's command:

“Krishna has descended to grant you the highest good. Therefore give up your sinful life and worship Him alone.” (CB, Madhya 13.84)

The brothers, eyes bloodshot, rushed at Them in anger shouting “Seize them!”, and Nityananda and Haridasa ran without looking back, crying, “Krishna! Govinda! Save us!”; old Haridasa could not keep up with Nityananda, but escaped: the drunken pursuers stumbled and fell behind. The two came to

Gaura and told Him everything, and Gangadasa and Srivasa explained to the Lord who these brothers were. “If they come here, I shall tear them to pieces,” said the Lord. But Nityananda answered, “Tear them You may, but while they are there I shall go nowhere any more. What are You so proud of? The pious chant Krishna's name by themselves; first make these two say ‘Govinda’ — to save such as Jagai and Madhai is greater glory; then the name ‘Saviour of the fallen’ will be Yours by right.” Vishvambhara smiled: “They were saved the moment they saw You. To whomever Nityananda wishes good, Krishna has already granted good — there is no doubt of it.” And Haridasa complained to Advaita that he would not go with Nityananda any more: His behaviour was reckless and unpredictable. But the flight of the all-powerful Nityananda is a mysterious lila: for later He alone delivered them.

One night Nityananda came to the brothers on purpose, to save them. “Who are You?” — “I am going to the Lord's house.” — “What is Your name?” — “My name is Avadhuta.” At that name Madhai in anger struck Him on the head with a shard of an earthen pot; the head was split, blood flowed, but Nityananda only thought of Govinda. Jagai, taking pity on Him, held back his brother's hand: “What is the use of beating a sannyasi?”[31] People ran to the Lord, and Mahaprabhu, seeing the blood, summoned the Sudarshana-chakra — the brothers saw it in terror; but Nityananda said, “When Madhai struck Me, Jagai saved Me. Forgive them — give Me their bodies as alms.” Gaura embraced Jagai: “By protecting Nityananda you have bought Me; from today you will obtain prema-bhakti,” — and showed him His four-armed form. Seeing the change in Jagai, Madhai too was changed and fell at the Lord's feet; but the Lord said, “Your guilt is heavier — you have shed Nityananda's blood, and Nityananda's body is higher than Mine; fall at His feet.” Madhai took shelter at Nityananda's feet, and He forgave him all his offences: “If in all My life I have gathered even a little piety, I give it all to Madhai”; at the Lord's word He embraced Madhai, entered into him and endowed him with every power. Both vowed to sin no more, took the shelter of Nitai-Gaura and became mahabhagavatas, and Gaura had the victory of Nityananda's mercy proclaimed.

But Madhai, remembering that he had shed Nityananda's blood, found no peace. Finding Him alone, he held His feet and with tears begged forgiveness, and Nityananda embraced him: “Does a father take offence at the slaps of his little son?” — and told him to build a ghat on the Ganga and humbly bow to everyone who came to bathe. From then on Madhai every day, with tears and pain, repeating “Krishna, Krishna,” served the ghat, prostrated himself before the Vaishnavas who came there and begged forgiveness for his offences. For his severe austerity he was called Madhai-brahmachari, and the ghat is called Madhai's ghat to this day (CB, Madhya 15.92–94).

The “Dari” Sannyasi; the Kazi; the Universal Form

Once, on the way to Advaita's house, Nityananda and Gaura called on a certain sannyasi. Gaura bowed, and he blessed Him: “May You have wealth, followers, beautiful women, learning.” Gaura objected: a sannyasi should bless otherwise — “may there be Krishna's mercy, may there be bhakti”; that is the true blessing. The sannyasi ridiculed Nimai as a foolish boy. Nityananda, seeing that such a seeker of enjoyment would not accept a good word, outwardly honoured him and “deceived” him: “We must go on business — give us bhiksha.” At the host's request both bathed in the Ganga and there accepted offerings to Krishna — milk, mangoes, jackfruit.

This sannyasi was a vamachari, a follower of the “left-hand path” — a “dari-sannyasi,” living with a woman — and he drank wine. Not understanding Who stood before him, he offered, “Shripada, shall I bring You some ‘ananda’?” Nityananda explained to Gaura that the vamacharis call wine “ananda,” and Gaura, crying “Vishnu! Vishnu!”, leapt into the Ganga and swam to Advaita's house. To deliver the fallen dari-sannyasi, Nityananda displayed the lila of taking a meal in his house. But blasphemers of Vaishnavas and Mayavadis, arrogant offenders of Vishnu and the Vaishnavas, are deprived of the mercy

even of this best of saviours: the dari-sannyasi may come to good, if not in this life then in another, the Mayavadi sannyasi — never. Vrindavana Dasa says:

“Although this sannyasi drank wine and kept close company with women, the Lord visited his house.” (CB, Madhya 19.96)

“Even if this sannyasi does not attain perfection in this life, he will attain it in the next. But blasphemers will never attain perfection.” (CB, Madhya 19.98)

The witnesses of this, he adds, are the sannyasis of Kashi, who cannot see the Lord (CB, Madhya 19.99)[32].

In Advaita's house he joyfully received Gaura and Nityananda; after a meal cooked by Sita, Nityananda in a childlike mood scattered rice all over the house, and Advaita, feigning anger, revealed to the devotees the greatness of the avadhuta.

At Mahaprabhu's bidding Nityananda went from town to town preaching the kirtana of Hari's name. The Kazi, hearing of the preaching and the noise of the kirtana, broke a mridanga; the hostile Hindus of Navadvipa supported him, called Nimai and Nitai “cheats” and said, “Soon the Kazi will stop Nityananda's street kirtana.” Then Gaura with Nityananda and all the Vaishnavas went out in a sankirtana procession through Navadvipa and subdued the Kazi. Nityananda danced in the procession beside the Lord; the order of the companies one biography gives in different ways: now Haridasa in front, Advaita in the middle and Gaurachandra Himself behind, now three companies led by Advaita, Haridasa and Srivasa. And before the procession, at the kirtana behind closed doors, Nityananda and Gadadhara whirled hand in hand, and Advaita, like a lion, rushed about the room (CB, Madhya 23.29–30)[33].

Once, while Nityananda was walking about Nadia, Mahaprabhu revealed His universal form in Srivasa's house. Nityananda inwardly knew it, came at once to Srivasa's door and roared, and Gaura showed Him His form containing countless universes.

The Lord's Sannyasa and Shantipur

The hostile students (paduya) of Navadvipa were piling up offences, reviling Gaura and plotting violence. For their own good Mahaprabhu resolved to take sannyasa and told the devotees of it in a riddle (hiyali); only Nityananda understood (according to another account of the same biography, Lokanatha was the first to learn of the coming sannyasa, while Nityananda, the Lord's “second Self,” learned of it only a day before). He grieved that Gaura's beautiful hair would be gone; Gaura explained to Him in private the reason for sannyasa, and Nityananda did not stand in the way but told the devotees, and, thinking of Shachi's separation, was stunned. According to the “Chaitanya-mangala,” when Shachi and Vishnupriya fell senseless, Nityananda tried to console them, and then devotees led by Chandrashekhara Acharya and Damodara Pandita followed Nityananda to Katwa.

At Katwa with the Lord were Nityananda, Chandrashekhara Acharya (Acharyaratna), Mukunda Datta, Gadadhara and Brahmananda; they performed all the rites[34]. When the barber touched Gaura's curls with the razor, Nityananda fell to the ground and wept.

After sannyasa the Lord wandered for three days through Rarh, intoxicated with love for Krishna, singing the song of the tridandi-bhikshu of Avanti, and going, as it seemed to Him, to Vrindavana; Nityananda followed Him. He taught the cowherd boys to point the Lord the way to Navadvipa as the way to Vrindavana — and so, wishing to show Him to the people of Navadvipa and bring Him to Shantipur, by a ruse He led Him to the Ganga, opposite Shantipur:

“But those children directed Him toward the Ganga. Intoxicated with spiritual bliss, He went there.” (CC, Madhya 3.19)

Meanwhile Nityananda told Chandrashekhara to go quickly to Advaita Acharya's house:

“I shall bring Sri Chaitanya to Advaita's house. But let Advaita wait for us with a boat on the bank of the Ganga.” (CC, Madhya 3.21)

“Then go to Navadvipa for mother Shachi and all the devotees.” (CC, Madhya 3.22)

So the Lord came to Shantipur and met there Shachi and the devotees of Navadvipa; the “Chaitanya-mangala” also describes Nityananda's conversation with Shachi. In Advaita's house Mahaprabhu and Nityananda ate Sita's enormous feast on whole banana leaves, while Advaita joked and talked with Them. At the kirtana Advaita danced holding Nityananda, and Haridasa behind Them. After His sannyasa the Lord stayed ten days in Shantipur.

The Way to Puri; the Broken Staff

At His mother's request that He settle in Puri, the Lord went from Shantipur through Chhatrabhoga to Nilachala. With Him went Nityananda, Mukunda Datta, Jagadananda, Damodara Pandita, Gadadhara Pandita, Govinda and Brahmananda[35]. At Remuna, before Kshira-chora Gopinatha, the Lord told His companions the story of Madhavendra Puri — as Ishvara Puri had told it to Him — and when, reciting Madhavendra's verse “ayi dīna-dayārdra nātha,” He fainted from love, Nityananda caught Him and laid Him on His lap (CC, Madhya 4.197–199). At Cuttack Nityananda told the story of Sakshi-Gopala. Mahaprabhu and Nityananda also passed through Bansdaha (Vamshadaha) near Jaleshvara (CB, Antya 2.263–264).

From Cuttack the Lord went to Bhuvaneshvara, for darshana of Shiva, and then to Kamalapur on the bank of the Bhargi. On the way the Lord's danda was carried by Jagadananda; going for alms, he left it with Nityananda:

“‘Please look after the Lord's danda. I shall gather alms and be back in a few minutes.’” (CB, Antya 2.204)

And Nityananda broke the danda into three pieces and set them floating down the river[36]. By this He showed that, though outwardly accepting the ekadanda, Mahaprabhu had in truth accepted the tridanda — yet Gaura needs no tridanda either: He is the Lord even of avadhuta-paramahamsas, who bear no signs of varnashrama at all[37].

The Lord was upset at the loss of His only possession and said that from here He would go alone — His companions might go ahead or behind; they chose behind. Reaching the Lion Gate of the temple, Nityananda, Mukunda, Jagadananda and Damodara learned that the Lord had been carried unconscious to Sarvabhauma's house. Gopinatha Acharya led them there, and they saw Gaurahari in a frenzy of love. Sarvabhauma bowed to Nityananda and sent them for darshana of Jagannatha with his son Chandaneshvara; their loud kirtana brought the Lord back to consciousness, and then Sarvabhauma fed them maha-prasada.

Nityananda, intoxicated with the rasa of Chaitanya, rushed to embrace Jagannatha. And once He climbed onto the golden throne, embraced the Deity of Balarama and put His garland on Himself.

In Puri

When He set out for the South, the Lord took none of His intimates with Him. Nityananda offered to go along — He knew the roads to the holy places of the South — but Mahaprabhu declined and, as though reproaching Nityananda, Jagadananda, Mukunda and Damodara, in fact praised their love:

“After accepting sannyasa I set out for Vrindavana, but You brought Me to the house of Advaita Acharya.” (CC, Madhya 7.19)

“On the way to Jagannatha Puri You broke My danda. All of you love Me boundlessly, but such deeds stand in the way of My plans.” (CC, Madhya 7.20)

Still, at Nityananda's request the Lord took a servant with Him — a simple brahmana named Krishnadasa[38] — to carry His kaupina, upper cloth and waterpot; Nityananda Himself arranged it.

Returning from the South, the Lord sent Krishnadasa ahead from Alalanatha to inform Nityananda and the others. Nityananda could not wait:

“Hearing of Mahaprabhu's imminent arrival, Nityananda Raya at once hurried to meet Him, unable to bear the waiting, so full was He of the feelings of divine love.” (CC, Madhya 9.339)

Jagadananda, Damodara and Mukunda danced with joy all along the road, and at the meeting the waves of love surged again. Soon the same Krishnadasa carried to Gauda, to Navadvipa, the news of the Lord's return[39].

Life in Puri took its course. When the Lord was distributing prasada to the devotees Himself and not eating, and they would not eat without Him, Svarupa Damodara asked Him to sit down to the meal together with Nityananda. Svarupa was very dear to both Advaita and Nityananda: arriving in Puri and receiving the Lord's embrace, he first of all bowed to Nityananda and Paramananda Puri. Svarupa Damodara, Raya Ramananda and Haridasa Thakura all honoured Nityananda's feet in Nilachala.

King Prataparudra longed to see the Lord, but Mahaprabhu, a sannyasi, refused to meet a ruler. Sarvabhauma advised not to ask Him directly, and Nityananda simply told the Lord of the king's resolve:

“You may think it proper or improper, but the fact is that King Prataparudra has resolved to become a mendicant beggar if he cannot meet You.” (CC, Madhya 12.19)

“He is ready to put on the ivory earrings of renunciation and give up his kingdom, which has become hateful to him without Your mercy.” (CC, Madhya 12.20)

The Lord remained unbending, pointing to the strict Damodara Pandita. Then Nityananda said: those rejected in love take their own lives, — and asked that, to save the king, He at least give a worn upper cloth (bahirvasa). The Lord could not refuse Him. Nityananda took the cloth from Govinda and sent it to the king through Sarvabhauma; the moment he touched it, Prataparudra felt love for God and began to worship it as the Lord Himself[40].

In the festivals of Nilachala Nityananda was always beside the Lord. When the Gundicha temple was cleaned, Mahaprabhu did not give heavy work to His elders:

“All except Nityananda, Advaita, Damodara, Bharati and Paramananda Puri filled pots and carried water.” (CC, Madhya 12.109)

At Gundicha, where kirtana went on three times a day, the Lord made now Advaita dance, now Nityananda, now Haridasa, Achyutananda, Vakreshvara and others. At the Ratha-yatra He anointed His companions with sandal paste with His own hand and adorned them with garlands:

“Advaita Acharya and Nityananda, too, felt immense happiness when the Lord's hand touched Them.” (CC, Madhya 13.31)

In the second kirtana party, led in song by Srivasa, the dancer was Nityananda (CC, Madhya 13.38–39); the Lord told Nityananda, Advaita, Haridasa and Vakreshvara each to dance in one of four parties. The dancing Lord was surrounded by three rings of guards: the inner one led by Nityananda, the second by

Kashishvara, Mukunda and others, the outer by Prataparudra with his soldiers. And in the bera-kirtana, when the devotees circled the temple in seven parties, each had its own dancer — Advaita, Nityananda, Vakreshvara, Achyutananda, Srivasa, Satyaraja Khan and Narahari — and the Lord passed from party to party so that each felt He was with it alone (CC, Antya 10.58–61).

Though Mahaprabhu now lived in Puri, in Gauda He still manifested Himself wherever He was loved:

“The Lord is always attracted by divine love, for such is His nature. Therefore Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu always manifested Himself in four places: in the home temple of Mother Shachi, wherever Nityananda Prabhu dances, in the kirtana of Srivasa Thakura and in the house of Raghava Pandita.” (CC, Antya 2.34)

Nityananda Himself came every year with the devotees of Bengal to Puri and spent the four months of the rains with the Lord.

On one of these visits Nityananda, having been to Jagannatha and shown there wondrous transformations of love, went to Tota, to the house of Gadadhara Pandita, for darshana of Gopinatha. Gadadhara, learning that Nityananda was in Puri, left off reading the “Bhagavata” and came out to meet Him. Nityananda had brought from Gauda fine rice worthy of the Deity and a beautiful coloured cloth for Gopinatha's service; Gadadhara cooked the rice with greens and vegetables from the garden of Yameshvara. Mahaprabhu, too, came to the offering: praising Nityananda's rice and Gadadhara's cooking, He honoured Gopinatha's prasada, and the three ate together in joy, while the devotees afterwards snatched up the remnants of Nitai-Gaura-Gadadhara's meal (CB, Antya 7).

When Rupa and Sanatana came to Puri, Mahaprabhu arranged for them to meet Advaita and Nityananda and asked Them to bless the brothers.

The Command to Preach in Gauda

One day Mahaprabhu, in private, told Nityananda to leave Puri with His companions and tirelessly preach pure devotion — prema-bhakti — in Gauda, delivering the low-born, the ignorant and the fallen. And He said that He Himself, ever remaining unseen, would watch Nityananda's dance: Nityananda's dance is one of the places where the Lord eternally manifests Himself (see above).

With Nityananda the Lord sent His own devotees:

“When Sri Chaitanya sent Nityananda to Bengal, He ordered these two devotees to go with Him.” (CC, Adi 11.14)

These were Ramadasa (Abhirama) and Gadadhara Dasa; Gadadhara Dasa became one of Nityananda's chief helpers in preaching sankirtana. According to the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Antya 5.231–233), there left Puri with Nityananda Ramadasa, Gadadhara Dasa, Raghunatha Vaidya-Ojha, Krishnadasa Pandita, Parameshvari Dasa and Purandara Pandita[41]. One of the biographies dates this command to the year 1434 of the Shaka era[42].

Before setting out, Nityananda empowered His companions, filling them with love of God:

“So Lord Nityananda and all His companions set out, overwhelmed by the feeling of divine love.” (CB, Antya 5.234)

“They forgot themselves in it completely. There was no end or limit to the signs of divine ecstasy that appeared in their bodies.” (CB, Antya 5.235)

On the way each lived in his own bhava. Gadadhara Dasa, forgetting himself like a girl of Vraja selling yogurt, laughed loudly and cried “Who will buy yogurt!” — and Nityananda noticed it. Abhirama, in the mood of a cowherd boy, stood nine hours in the tribhanga pose, bent in three places, unaware of the

outer world (CB, Antya 5.237). Krishnadasa and Parameshvari shouted “hoi! hoi!” like the cowherd boys of Vraja, and Purandara climbed a tree crying “I am Angada!” and leapt down.

Coming to Gauda, Nityananda went all over it as a wandering parivrajaka, preaching the Name and love of God. Whomever He met, He took a straw between His teeth and begged: “Buy Me — worship Gaurahari.” The avadhuta wandered for two tasks: preaching prema and subduing the godless. Lochana Dasa, who in the “Chaitanya-mangala” glorified more his guru Narahari as the Lord's dearest companion and wrote little of Nityananda's glory, later, fearing to offend Him, composed several songs about Him that devotees especially love. In one (“nitāi guṇa-maṇi…”) he sings that Nitai brought a flood of prema to Gauda, passing over neither the downtrodden nor the sinners, and went from house to house giving out a love unattainable even for Brahma — whoever has not worshipped Nitai ruins himself. In another (“akrodha paramānanda…”) — that Nityananda, knowing neither anger nor pride, roams the town with a blade of grass between His teeth, asks everyone “buy Me — worship Gaura Hari” and falls to the ground like a golden mountain in the dust; whoever has not become attached to such an avatara is a sinner. And in the song “parama karuṇa pahun dui jana…” Lochana glorifies the two Lords, Nitai and Gaurachandra, boundlessly merciful, the essence of all avataras: “Brother, worship Chaitanya and Nitai with firm faith” — in the three worlds there is none like Them, and Their mercy makes even birds and beasts weep.

Ramachandra Khan

Ramachandra Khan, the zamindar of Benapol (Jessore district), hated the Vaishnavas fiercely. Out of envy he sent a young prostitute to Haridasa Thakura to ruin his dharma; by Haridasa's mercy she became a great devotee, and Khan's envy only grew (CC, Antya 3).

On His preaching round Nityananda came to him too. As the Inner Controller, He knew of his offences against Haridasa: He is most merciful, but with the offender of a Vaishnava He is angry. Nityananda sat down in Khan's durga-mandapa and asked for shelter. The proud man sent word through his people: He could stay with His party in the cowshed — there was no other place. Nityananda, still more displeased, left at once, saying: “This house is not for Vaishnavas — it is fit only for mlecchas who kill cows.” Thus Nityananda Raya, “never angry, supreme bliss” (akrodha paramānanda, as Lochana Dasa sings of Him), showed a lila of anger towards the enemy of the Vaishnavas and left both his house and his village.

Khan had a servant dig up the earth where Nityananda had sat and sprinkle the place with water mixed with cow dung. The fruit of the offence was not long in coming: soon a vizier of the Muslim ruler, a tax collector, took up quarters in that same durga-mandapa; he bound and carried off Khan with his wife and sons, plundered Benapol for three days and for three days cooked forbidden meat in Khan's house. Khan lost his caste, his wealth and his people, and his house and village were ruined. Though Nityananda is most merciful, He does not forgive the offender of a Vaishnava, and a place where a great devotee is offended perishes.

Panihati: Raghava Pandita

Wandering along the banks of the Ganga, Nityananda, drawn by the pure devotion of Raghava Pandita, came to Panihati. According to the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (8.156–158), Ramadasa and Gadadhara Dasa were with Him, and first of all He visited Raghava's house; one of the biographies also names the three Ghosha brothers. The kirtana begun there filled the universe with joy. Nityananda flooded Raghava's house with love, delighting Raghava, Makaradhvaja Kara and others; when the Ghoshas began to sing, He danced in trance to the singing of Madhava Ghosha — the finest kirtaniya on earth.

Then He sat on the throne of Vishnu, and Raghava and his companions performed His abhisheka according to the shastras, dressed Him and adorned Him with a garland; He sat on the throne again, and

Raghava held an umbrella over Him (according to one account, Makaradhvaja Kara). In trance Nityananda told Raghava to bring at once a garland of kadamba flowers. Raghava objected that the kadamba was not yet in bloom; Nityananda told him to look near the house — and Raghava found kadamba flowers on a lemon (jambira) tree and garlanded Him[43]. Soon the house filled with the fragrance of damanaka flowers, and Nityananda explained: Mahaprabhu Himself had come from Nilachala wearing a garland of damanaka to hear the kirtana and watch the dance (BR 12.3645–3647).

He told everyone to give up their affairs, forget body and home, and sing Krishna's name without cease:

“Therefore you should give up all your other occupations and immerse yourselves in the unceasing glorification of Lord Krishna.” (CB, Antya 5.298)

“By constantly glorifying Sri Krishna Chaitanyachandra you will taste the sweetness of divine love of God in all its fullness.” (CB, Antya 5.299)

Nityananda stayed in Panihati three months. With His companions He would come to eat in Raghava's house, and all praised his cooking; and the Lord, taking Raghava aside, explained to him His oneness with Nityananda — “another form of Balarama”: “Sri Nityananda is My second body; serve Him with care — and you will easily obtain even what is rarely given by serving the great lord of yoga”; and Makaradhvaja Kara He told to serve Raghava with love — that is service to Him Himself. It is also said that Nityananda gave Panihati over to Kamalakara Pippalai[44].

The Chida-dadhi Festival

Hearing that Nityananda was in Panihati, young Raghunatha Dasa decided: by the mercy of the saviour of the fallen he would gain his freedom. With his father's permission he crossed the Ganga and found Nityananda seated under a tree on a rise by the river amid His companions, to the sound of kirtana; seeing Him from afar, Raghunatha fell flat. Nityananda was told who it was.

“Hearing this, Nityananda said: ‘Oh! This thief has come to meet Me again. Come here to Me, then, don't be afraid. Today I shall punish you.’” (CC, Antya 6.47)

Nityananda drew him to Himself, placed His feet on his head and announced the “punishment”:

“‘You do not come close, but keep your distance like a thief. But I have caught you and shall punish you today.” (CC, Antya 6.50)

“I want you to feed all My companions yogurt and flat rice.’ Hearing these words, Raghunatha became inexpressibly happy.” (CC, Antya 6.51)

So, understanding the young man's innermost desires, He assigned him service to the Vaishnavas. Raghava Pandita added foods that had not touched boiled rice and watched in wonder this “picnic” of Nityananda's by the river. Present at the festival were Gadadhara Dasa, Mahesha Pandita and Jagadisha Pandita[45].

Mahaprabhu Himself came too[46]. Nityananda and Mahaprabhu ate on the bank of the Ganga as the cowherd boys on the bank of the Yamuna, and with Them ate Their companions, many brahmanas and countless men and women. In the afternoon Nityananda went to Raghava's house and spent the evening in kirtana and dance; drawn by His dancing, Mahaprabhu came again, and to show Raghava's good fortune They sat together and accepted his meal — fine rice, vegetables, cakes, sweet rice. (According to one account, the prasada Raghava had brought Nityananda set aside for the night.) The remnants of Mahaprabhu's meal — according to the same account, of both brothers — Raghava gave to Raghunatha.

Next day Raghunatha asked through Raghava how he might attain Mahaprabhu's feet. Nityananda placed His feet on his head and answered:

“Gaurachandra Himself came to save you. From now on everything that hindered and bound you is removed by His sweet will.” (CC, Antya 6.141)

“Sri Chaitanya will entrust you to the care and protection of His closest servant, Svarupa Damodara. Thus you will gain the shelter of His lotus feet.” (CC, Antya 6.142)

“Go home with this assurance. And very soon you will gain, without any hindrance, the shelter of Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu.” (CC, Antya 6.143)

On Raghava's advice Raghunatha gave a generous dakshina to Nityananda and His companions and, having received their blessing, considered his life fulfilled. This festival is celebrated in Panihati to this day — as the chida-dadhi-mahotsava, the festival of flat rice with yogurt.

Through Gauda: Gadadhara Dasa, Saptagrama, Shantipur

Once Nityananda wished to wear ornaments — and at once countless ornaments appeared; putting them on, He wandered in the dress of a cowherd (gopa-vesha). So He went round the homes of devotees in the villages on both banks of the Ganga, spreading kirtana everywhere.

In the house of Gadadhara Dasa He found the master in the bhava of a gopi: with a pot of Ganga water on his head he was crying “Who will buy milk!” Seeing this, Nityananda took from his temple the Deity of Bala-Gopala whom Gadadhara Dasa served, and danced, pressing Him to His chest. There, too, the dana-lila was played — the pastime of Krishna levying “toll” on the gopis:

“Gadadhara Dasa was in bliss, overwhelmed by the feelings of a gopi. In his house Nityananda played in the drama ‘Danakeli.’” (CC, Adi 11.17)

Madhavananda Ghosha sang the song of the dana-khanda-lila, and Nityananda danced and sank into deep trance; that is why the house of Gadadhara Dasa is called the place of the dana-lila[47].

Then Nityananda came to Mayapur to Shachi, spent a few days in Khardaha and set out with His companions for Saptagrama:

“Having spent a few days in Khardaha, Nityananda set out with His companions for Saptagrama.” (CB, Antya 5.443)

“In great bliss Nityananda bathed at that ghata together with His companions.” (CB, Antya 5.448)

“Lord Nityananda stayed on the bank of the Triveni in the house of the fortunate Uddharana Datta.” (CB, Antya 5.449)

“Uddharana Datta sincerely worshipped Nityananda's feet with body, mind and speech.” (CB, Antya 5.450)

Nityananda accepted Uddharana's service and gladly ate what he cooked, won over by His devotee's love, and all around He preached love for the Name. Uddharana's presence purified the whole caste of gold merchants; by Nityananda's mercy the banik traders, though considered low and unlearned, attained prema-bhakti, and even a hostile yavana took shelter at His feet. Sri Krishna Chaitanya and Nityananda wanted to show that a great devotee can appear in any family and caste — therefore some of Their devotees were born in such families. By worshipping Uddharana and pleasing him one quickly gains Nityananda's mercy, and through it love for Krishna.

One biography remarks with sorrow that later some born in the community Nityananda had delivered, calling themselves devotees, came to oppose Him.

Chaitanya and Nityananda delivered everyone — sinners and offenders alike. Ordinarily offences keep the holy name from bearing fruit, but with Them it is otherwise:

“But such considerations do not apply to the names of Sri Chaitanya and Nityananda Prabhu. One who chants these holy names will gradually be purified of all possible offences and, with tears in his eyes, will taste the nectar of divine love for Krishna.” (CC, Adi 8.31)

Bhaktivinoda Thakura explains: whoever takes shelter of Chaitanya and Nityananda with faith is quickly purified of offences.

After the chida-dadhi festival Mahesha Pandita, too, followed Nityananda to Saptagrama. From there Nityananda came to Shantipur and delighted in sankirtana with Advaita; by His mercy hundreds of villains, thieves and robbers attained the good.

The Robber Chief

In Navadvipa Nityananda was staying at that time in the house of Hiranya Pandita. The son of a Navadvipa brahmana had become the chief of a robber band; coveting Nityananda's ornaments, he dogged His steps.

On the first night the band surrounded with weapons the house where kirtana was going on and waited for everyone to fall asleep — but by Nityananda's will it was the robbers who fell asleep. They woke to the cawing of crows, hid their weapons, went to the Ganga and blamed one another. On the second night, after worshipping Chandi with wine and meat, they again surrounded the house — and saw a host of armed guards singing the name of Hari; in amazement they did not dare go out to their work for some ten days. On the third night, a very dark one, they entered the house — and all went blind: they fell into pits of leftovers, onto thorns, into rubbish heaps, and on top of that a storm with hail broke out.

Then the chief remembered Nityananda's inconceivable power, fell at His feet, begged forgiveness and glorified Him. Nityananda placed His foot on his head; the offences of the chief and of the whole band were removed, and they attained prema-bhakti. Through the influence of the former chief, thieves and robbers everywhere turned to righteousness and took shelter of Gaura:

“They stopped stealing, harming others and doing immoral deeds, and their conduct became saintly.” (CB, Antya 5.697)

“Other avataras of the Supreme Lord do not give shelter so easily, but Nityananda always moved each and every one to surrender to Lord Chaitanya.” (CB, Antya 5.700)

And Vrindavana Dasa ranks a brahmana who does not accept Nityananda no higher than a thief and robber — and such a one Nityananda teaches through robbers (CB, Antya 5.701).

A Brahmana's Doubt; Slander of the Avadhuta

Nityananda preached Gaura's name wearing ornaments and fragrant garlands, His lips red with betel. A brahmana from Navadvipa, a former schoolfellow of Gaura and His devotee, came to doubt Nityananda and went with this to the Lord. Gaura answered: the conduct of the highest, the uttama-adhikari, is not subject to the general rules and is not given for imitation; whoever would imitate Rudra, who drank the kalakuta poison, will surely die; and if the highest adhikari outwardly does something reprehensible, not only blasphemy of him but even mockery brings ruin[28].

“His deeds lie beyond the jurisdiction of any rules and injunctions. Who is able to understand Him?” (CB, Antya 6.118)

“‘Even if Sri Nityananda takes the hand of an outcaste woman or enters a wine shop, His lotus feet still remain an object of worship even for Brahma.’” (CB, Antya 6.124)

“Strong faith in Nityananda arose in him. Then that brahmana returned home to Navadvipa.” (CB, Antya 6.126)

Bhaktivinoda Thakura in the “Sajjana-toshani” (8.9) rejects the judgments of the “adhyakshikas,” worldly judges: though Nityananda was an avadhuta, never once in His life did He show bad conduct, and shame on those who call Him immoral. People of bad conduct slander the acharya to pass off their vices as virtues. Many pseudo-Vaishnavas say that Nityananda ate fish and meat, ascribe to Mahaprabhu dealings with women and count Him among the “nava-rasikas,” and slander Rupa Gosvami and Ramananda. All this is the slander of the age of Kali, meant to justify one's own vices: the avadhuta Nityananda is spotless.

Shivananda Sena and the Last Coming to Puri

Every year it was Shivananda Sena who led the Bengali devotees to Puri: he paid the road tolls for everyone and knew the way through Orissa well. Once he was delayed at the toll station, leaving everyone at the crossing, and without him no lodging could be found — all waited under a tree. Nityananda, like a hungry cowherd boy of Vraja, acting out the pangs of hunger, feigned anger and cursed: “Shiva has not come and found us lodging, and I am dying of hunger — may his three sons die!” Shivananda's wife wept. But Shivananda, on arriving, told her: let all three die, since we have caused Nityananda Prabhu inconvenience.

“Having spoken thus, Shivananda went without delay to Nityananda. But Nityananda rose and kicked him.” (CC, Antya 12.24)

Shivananda took this blow as a sign of the greatest good fortune. He found lodging in a milkman's house, brought Nityananda there and glorified Him:

“Under the pretext of punishment You have granted me Your mercy. Who can understand the nature and greatness of Your deeds?” (CC, Antya 12.28)

“Even Brahma cannot touch the dust of Your beautiful feet. Yet with Your foot You have touched my body, full of sin.” (CC, Antya 12.29)

Pleased, Nityananda embraced him. So Shivananda received the touch of His feet, unattainable even for Brahma. But Shivananda's nephew Shrikanta was upset that Nityananda had kicked a companion of Mahaprabhu honoured by all, and went on ahead to Puri alone; the Lord knew his thoughts.

This was Nityananda's last coming to Puri — in the year Haridasa Thakura departed. Mahaprabhu had forbidden Him to come and told Him to preach in Gauda; that same year He sent Jagadananda to Navadvipa with news for His mother. But Nityananda, having taken leave of Shachi, could not bear the separation and joined the Bengali pilgrims (CC, Antya 12).

In Puri Nityananda stayed in a flower garden. Gaura came to Him alone and, circling Him, glorified Him with the words: let Nityananda take the hand of a yavana woman or enter a wine shop — His feet are worthy of Brahma's worship[48]. The ornaments on Nityananda, Gaura said — gold, gems, pearls, diamonds, silver — are the nine kinds of bhakti themselves, and the ignorant do not grasp it; Nityananda and His companions are the Baladeva of Vraja and His cowherd friends. And again and again Gaura forbade Him to come to Nilachala: “Stay in Gauda and spread what I desire — there You will have My eternal company.”

Other Homes and Places of Gauda

In Gopalpur Nityananda with His retinue stayed in the house of Raja Krishnananda Datta, Narottama's father, and blessed him generously. In Shrikhanda, when Mahaprabhu and Nityananda, coming to the house of Narahari Sarakara, wished for honey, Narahari turned the water of the pond by the house into honey; since then the pond has been called Madhu-pushkarini. At Nupura-kunda near the shripata of Lavanga (Akai-hat, near Katwa), tradition says, an ankle bell fell — according to some, that of

Raghunandana, the son of Mukunda of Shrikhanda, according to others, that of Nityananda Prabhu.

As far as Ramakeli the Lord was accompanied by Nityananda — according to one account, with seven companions and Haridasa. There Rupa and Sanatana, coming to the Lord by night, first met Nityananda and Haridasa:

“In the dead of night they came to the house of Sri Chaitanya. First they met Sri Nityananda and Thakura Haridasa.” (CC, Madhya 1.183)

“And They informed Mahaprabhu that Rupa and Sanatana had come to see Him.” (CC, Madhya 1.184)

To show that a conditioned soul is saved by the mercy of devotees, the Lord told Nityananda, Haridasa, Srivasa, Gadadhara and others to bless the brothers, and they touched the feet of His companions, among them the feet of Nityananda.

With the place called Prematali on the bank of the Padmavati is linked the tradition of the love left for Narottama: by one version, Mahaprabhu, travelling in Bengal and having sent Nityananda to Puri, wept there in ecstasy and kept prema for Narottama; by another (the “Prema-vilasa”), at Kanai-natshala the Lord in kirtana called out “Narottama!” and to Nityananda's question replied: “You do not know Your own glory: in Puri You shed tears of love day after day; I have gathered Your love and shall leave it in the keeping of the Padmavati for Narottama”; by a third, it was Nityananda Himself who bathed at Prematali and left prema there for Narottama[49].

According to the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (1.765–772), young Jiva Gosvami met Nityananda in Navadvipa, in Srivasa's house. Nityananda with a father's tenderness touched his head with His feet, raised him, embraced him tightly and said in ecstasy: “I rushed here from Khardaha only for your sake.” He told Srivasa and others to bless Jiva, kept him with Him for some time, and then sent him west: “Hurry to Vraja — the Lord has given that place to your family.” By Nityananda's mercy Jiva went round all the holy places of Navadvipa-dhama; in Bhaktivinoda Thakura's “Navadvipa-dhama-mahatmya” it is Nityananda who guides him through Navadvipa. At Shridhara's house, He says there, the Lord used to stop the kirtana to let the devotees rest — this is the “vishrama-sthana,” the place of rest — and He invites Jiva to rest there too.

Marriage: Vasudha and Jahnava

Nityananda, the avadhuta bound by no rules, in Gauda took on the role of a householder as well. Not all the biographies speak of it: one of them, which calls Him the eldest son of Hadai and Padmavati (but does not name their other children), is silent about the marriage, as it is silent about the date and place of His departure; of the identifications according to the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” it gives only two — Baladeva, and Jahnava as Ananga-manjari (the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” itself, 66, gives both opinions — some call Ananga-manjari Vasudha, others Jahnava — and accepts both as true; see below, “Identifications”).

Nityananda's wives were the two daughters of Surya Dasa Sarakhela (Sarahela), elder brother of Gauridasa Pandita — Vasudha and Jahnava. By one account, Surya Dasa lived in Shaligrama and served as a secretary to the Muslim authorities; by another, his house and temple stood in Ambika, a little west of the shripata of Gauridasa[50]. He and his younger brother Krishnadasa Sarakhela had firm faith in Nityananda:

“Suryadasa Sarakhela and his brother Krishnadasa had unshakable faith in Nityananda. They were full of love of God.” (CC, Adi 11.25)

The “Bhakti-ratnakara” (12th wave) tells in detail of this wedding, performed “according to human custom.” Its arrangement was taken on by Krishnadasa, son of Harihora (by some, a king) of Borgachi

(Boroganchhi) near Shaligrama, a dear devotee of Nityananda[51]. An old brahmana of Shaligrama, seeing Surya Dasa searching for a bridegroom for his two daughters, told him that Nityananda was their eternal husband. And Surya Dasa saw Nityananda in a dream as Balarama Himself — in incomparable radiance filling all ten directions, in wondrous ornaments — and on either side of Him his daughters in the forms of Revati and Varuni[52]. “Until He accepts them, I shall have no peace,” he told a brahmana friend.

Surya Dasa sent the brahmana to Navadvipa to Srivasa, with whom Nityananda was then living. Srivasa rejoiced and passed the matter on to Nityananda, and the merciful Nityananda had Surya Dasa assured that He would fulfil his wish; Advaita, on hearing it, said: “Let it happen soon.” Srivasa, Advaita, Chandrashekhara, Murari Gupta and others gathered and sang sankirtana; Nityananda arrived, and the devotees from Shaligrama arrived too. Surya Dasa ran out to meet Him, fell at Nityananda's feet and held them, flooding the ground with tears and unable to utter a word; Nityananda smiled, could not hold back His joyful laughter and, bestowing full mercy on him, embraced him. Gauridasa, seeing his brother, was in ecstasy too.

According to one of the biographies, when Surya Dasa offered his daughters at Nityananda's feet, He mercifully showed him the same vision in waking as well (by the “Bhakti-ratnakara”, Surya Dasa saw it in a dream): both shone brighter than mountains of gold and kunkuma, in jewels and many-coloured garments, and Surya Dasa fainted with love. The adhivasa on the eve of the wedding was held in the house of Krishnadasa Sarakhela in Shaligrama in the presence of all the brahmanas of Borgachi and Shaligrama; Surya Dasa bowed to Nityananda's feet and, according to rite and custom, gave Him both daughters. “How fortunate is Surya Dasa,” says the “Bhakti-ratnakara”, “he gave his two daughters to Nityananda-chandra” (BR 12.3983).

After the wedding Nityananda stayed for a while in Shaligrama, and then with His two wives came to Navadvipa to Shachi Devi and bowed at her feet; Shachi joyfully embraced Vasudha and Jahnava, sat them on her lap and pinched their cheeks affectionately. At Shachimata's request Nityananda lived for a time in Navadvipa, then in Saptagrama with Uddharana Datta, and then settled for good in Khardaha on the Ganga[53]. In Khardaha He had a house where His two energies, Vasudha and Jahnava, lived; Parameshvari Dasa served them there.

Nityananda's marriage is no worldly union. The eternal associates of the Lord, descending into the world, act in a human way, but never touch maya and are never entangled in family life; their unearthly nature is recognised by those who have surrendered to Vishnu and the Vaishnavas. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati says: Nityananda had no material body like ours; He entered into no material intimacy with a material body and did not sink into the material rasa of separation[54].

Jahnava and Vasudha after Nityananda's Departure

Jahnava is Nityananda's shakti, “Nityananda-svarupini,” His other self. Bhaktivinoda Thakura in the “Kalyana-kalpataru” prays to her as “Nityananda-shakti” — the energy of Nityananda, devotion to Krishna and to her guru personified. Without the mercy of Jahnava Devi, the Vaishnavas say, no one will cross the ocean of births or attain the service of Nityananda and of Those whom He worships — Gaura Hari and Radha-Krishna. The “Bhakti-ratnakara” (10th wave) glorifies her as the daughter of Surya Pandita and the wife of Nityananda, honoured by the whole world, skilled in giving out the pearls of prema.

After Nityananda's departure Jahnava became the centre of His circle. She came to the festival at Kheturi and there blessed Shrinivasa and Narottama, visited Katwa, Shantipur and Navadvipa, made the journey to Vraja and at Radha-kunda blessed Raghunatha Dasa (one biography calls her here

“Nityananda's widow”). Returning from Vraja to Khardaha, she told Vasudha and Virabhadra of the journey; Virachandra and Ganga received her there. In Khardaha Shrinivasa and Narottama visited Jahnava and Vasudha, Virabhadra and Parameshvari Dasa; Shrinivasa was then going round the shripatas of the companions of Mahaprabhu and Nityananda.

With Jahnava to Kheturi went Nityananda's companions: Minaketana Ramadasa, Abhirama, Murari Chaitanya, Jnanadasa, Kamalakara Pippalai, and also Krishna Mishra, Shripati, Shrinidhi, Parameshvari Dasa, Balarama Dasa, Vrindavana Dasa Thakura and others (BR 10.372–375)[55]; Kala Krishnadasa, too, was with her when she came to Katwa. After the departure of Uddharana Datta, Jahnava visited his house.

Parameshvari Dasa, a dear companion of Nityananda, by Jahnava's mercy saw Gopinatha together with Radha in Vrindavana; returning to Khardaha, he told Jahnava and Vasudha of it, and Jahnava told him to install Radha-Gopinatha at Antpur. The Deities of Purushottama (Nagara) were moved together with the Deity of Jahnava Mata to Sahebdanga-Berigram, and then to Chanduregram (Anubhashya to CC, Adi 11.39). Nityananda Dasa, author of the “Prema-vilasa,” is a diksha disciple of Jahnava Mata. Jahnava departed on the shukla-navami of the month of Vaishakha.

Seeing the devotion of Purushottama's son, Kanu Thakura, from his earliest years, Nityananda named him Shishu Krishnadasa. The boy lost his mother early (she too was called Jahnava). From here the biographies differ: by one, Nityananda's wife Jahnava, it is said, adopted him and took him with her to Vrindavana; by another, Jahnava-mata took him to Vrindavana at five, and there Jiva and the other Gosvamis named him Kanai Thakura; by a third, on learning of his mother's departure, Nityananda Himself came to Purushottama's house and took the “twelve-year-old child” to His own home in Khardaha[56].

Descendants: Virachandra and Ganga

Jahnava had no sons; Vasudha bore Virabhadra (Virachandra, Birchandra) Gosvami and a daughter, Ganga Devi. According to the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (9.413–414, 420–421), Virabhadra is Nityananda's only son, famed as His branch. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati in the “Anubhashya” calls him the son of Vasudha — Nityananda's “other wife” — and a disciple of Jahnava: according to the “Prema-vilasa,” seeing her four-armed, he resolved to accept her as his guru.

Krishnadasa Kaviraja devotes special lines to Virabhadra:

“On the branch of Sri Nityananda there grew a great branch — Virabhadra Gosani. There is no counting all the twigs and shoots to which this branch gave rise.” (CC, Adi 11.8)

“Sri Virabhadra is the Supreme Himself. But He called Himself only a great devotee. And though He is above all the injunctions of the Vedas, He strictly performed all the rituals and injunctions.” (CC, Adi 11.9)

“He is the main pillar in the hall of loving devotion to Sri Chaitanya. He knew Himself to be the Supreme God, but outwardly showed no pride.” (CC, Adi 11.10)

“And to this day, by the mercy of the all-glorious Sri Virabhadra Gosani, the holy names of Sri Chaitanya and Nityananda are chanted everywhere in the world.” (CC, Adi 11.11)

And again: Virabhadra is the best of all Nityananda's branches, and there is no end to the shoots that grew from it (CC, Adi 11.56).

Virabhadra's wives were Shrimati, daughter of Yadunandana (Yadunatha) Acharya and his wife Vidyunmala of Jhamatpur (Hooghly district), and Narayani. By one biography, the marriage was arranged by Jahnava, and both daughters-in-law were her disciples; by another, Yadunandanacharya

was himself a disciple of Virachandra. As vishnu-tattva, says one biography, Virabhadra had three shaktis, and the Shri-shakti is Shrimati[57]. He had no children of his own. Three are named as his adopted sons: the eldest, Gopijana-vallabha, who lived in Latagram near Mankar (Burdwan district); the middle one, Ramakrishna, at Gayespur near Malda; and the youngest, Ramachandra, who lived in Khardaha, a pure shrotriya brahmana of the Batavyal family, of the Shandilya gotra. In the “Bhakti-ratnakara” all three are called Virabhadra's sons; but, explains one biography, “sons” here means disciples, for their gotras differ.

Virabhadra's followers, called “neras” and “neris,” numbered, it is said, twelve hundred and thirteen hundred, and all lived restrained lives; later laxity, the eating of fish and the like appeared among them, and many of them earned contempt.

With the permission of his mother Vasudha, Virabhadra went to Vrindavana and went round Vraja with the blessings of Bhugarbha Gosvami and Jiva (BR 13). In the old temple of Shyamasundara in Khardaha a manuscript of the “Bhagavatam” is kept, copied by tradition by Virabhadra, and in the opinion of some by Nityananda Himself. Virabhadra brought to Khardaha the stone from which the Deities of Shyamasundara, Radhavallabha and Nandadulala were carved (hence the name Shyamasundar-ghat). He also established the custom of celebrating Nityananda's appearance in Khardaha. Virabhadra's own appearance day is usually reckoned the krishna-navami of the month of Kartika, and by the “Gaudiya-vaishnava-abhidhana” the shukla-chaturdashi of the month of Agrahayana.

Virachandra was in Shrikhanda at the festival of Narahari Sarakara's departure, where Shrinivasa performed the rites; in Ambika the followers of Chaitanya joyfully welcomed him as Nityananda's son. Tradition says that only a Vishnu-shila or a consecrated Deity could bear the obeisance of Abhirama Thakura — anything else cracked or crumbled; Nityananda's son Virachandra and His daughter Ganga Devi received his obeisances unharmed, which confirmed their divinity, and Abhirama composed ashtakas in their honour.

Ganga Devi's husband was Madhavacharya (Madhava Chattopadhyaya) of Jirat (Hooghly); in the opinion of some, he was a disciple of Purushottama (Nagara), in the opinion of others — of Nityananda or of Jahnava.

Descendants of Nityananda were spoken of in later times as well. From His line came the well-known scholar Shyamlal Gosvami, who studied at the “Sarasvata-chatushpathi” (1897). And in 1911 those who called themselves descendants of Nityananda and other companions took the side of the smartas against the Vaishnavas at the debate in Balighai (Midnapore), where Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati spoke.

Disciples and Companions

Nityananda's companions are without number. They are always in bliss, and they have no other occupation than sankirtana:

“All the companions of Nityananda Prabhu were always filled with transcendental bliss.” (CB, Antya 5.712)

“They devoted themselves to nothing but holy sankirtana and were always intoxicated with the mood of cowherd boys.” (CB, Antya 5.713)

The chief among them are the twelve gopalas (dvadasha-gopala), Balarama's friends in Vraja; all of them hold the seats of “patra-raja” in the Universal Assembly of Vaishnava Kings (Vishva-vaishnava-raja-sabha). One biography lists them thus: Abhirama Thakura, Sundarananda Thakura, Kamalakara Pippalai, Gauridasa Pandita, Parameshvari Dasa, Dhananjaya Pandita, Mahesha

Pandita, Purushottama Pandita, Kalakrishna Dasa, Purushottama (two different Purushottamas, as printed), Uddharana Thakura and Shridhara. Nityananda's companions are like Him: generous, saving the fallen, fulfilling desires, and many showed wondrous powers. They are an extension of His mercy: they seek out the still more fallen, and through them Nityananda distributes His mercy; for the sinners and offenders of this world have no shelter other than the mercy of Nityananda.

Abhirama Thakura (Ramadasa, Abhirama Gopala) is Nityananda's “dearest” devotee. By His order he became a great acharya and preacher and saved many godless people; he was endowed with His power (according to the “Bhakti-ratnakara,” as if Nityananda had entered him), and at His request married Malini (BR 4.103–108).

Sundarananda (in Vraja, Sudama, GGD 127) is a branch of Nityananda:

“Sundarananda, a branch of Sri Nityananda, is known as one of His closest servants. With him Nityananda performed deeds repeating the pastimes of Vraja.” (CC, Adi 11.23)

The “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Antya 5.728) calls him the eldest among Nityananda's companions. Like Nityananda, he is a saviour of the fallen; one biography ascribes to him the miracle of the kadamba blossoming on a lemon tree (cf. note 43).

Gauridasa Pandita — in Vraja, Subala (GGD 128) — is one of the twelve gopalas and one of Nityananda's dearest companions. His body, mind and speech were given to Nityananda (CB, Antya 5.730):

“For the sake of serving Sri Nityananda, Gauridasa sacrificed the support of his class and family. So he accepted Sri Chaitanya and Nityananda as the Lords of his whole life.” (CC, Adi 11.27)

He is one of the most important sub-branches of Nityananda's branch. As Nityananda gave out Krishna-prema to all, without distinguishing the worthy from the unworthy, as if intoxicated, so His close companion Gauridasa showed great power in preaching.

With Gauridasa is linked the tradition of the Gaura-Nitai Deities of Ambika. When the Lord and Nityananda were about to go from Ambika-Kalna to Puri, Gauridasa begged Them to stay; the Lord promised to leave him His own form and Nityananda's: “My murti is the same as I.” The two brothers manifested Themselves in two perfect Deity forms, tasted what Gauridasa had cooked, left him the “two Lords,” and Themselves went to Puri[58].

These Deities, it is said, once revealed Themselves to Gauridasa as Krishna and Balarama in the dress of cowherd boys — with sticks, Krishna with flute and peacock feather, forest garlands round Their necks, anklets on Their feet — reminding him that he was Subala, and returned to the altar as Gaura and Nityananda. Seeing how old Gauridasa toiled, They refused to eat and asked him to cook more simply — shak on a banana leaf — and the ornaments he wished to adorn Them with They put on Themselves. Once the Deities left the altar and sang and danced in the kirtana of Hridaya Chaitanya on the bank of the Ganga, and seeing the anger of Gauridasa, who came out with a cudgel, became invisible — They entered the heart of Hridaya Chaitanya. Gaura and Nityananda always abide in Gauridasa's house; later, in Ambika, Gaura and Nityananda appeared in a kirtana, and Jahnava saw Gauridasa with Them in a dream. In the present temple of Ambika are Deities of Gaura-Nitai (together with Radha-Krishna, Jagannatha, Balarama and Sita-Rama); there too, by one biography, are kept a manuscript of the “Gita” — by tradition written in the Lord's own hand (not all accept this) — and the Lord's oar.

Gauridasa's (Subala's) disciple Hridaya Chaitanya worshipped Gaura-Nitai in the mood of friendship (sakhya). From Gauridasa runs the succession called the “line of Nityananda”: Gauridasa Pandita — Hridaya Chaitanya — Shyamananda — Rasikananda — Nayanananda — Radha-Damodara — Baladeva Vidyabhushana.

Uddharana Datta is one of the twelve gopalas (Subahu, GGD 129). He was born in 1481 in Saptagrama to help Nityananda:

“The best of the great devotees of God, Uddharana Datta, served the lotus feet of Sri Nityananda with all reverence.” (CC, Adi 11.41)

As one of Nityananda's closest companions he is called “parama-parama-patita-pavana,” the saviour of the most fallen; whoever takes shelter of him attains service at the feet of Nityananda and Gauranga. According to the “Chaitanya-bhagavata,” he has the right to serve Nityananda; possessing great wealth, he gave all his senses to Nityananda's service. In his shripata at Saptagrama is the six-armed Mahaprabhu whom he installed and himself served, to His right the Deity of Nityananda, to His left that of Gadadhara. The Nitai-Gaura Deities that Uddharana installed in Uddharanpur near Katwa were, it is said, taken to the capital of the Banowari rajas.

Parameshvari Dasa is one of Nityananda's most important companions, who appeared to enrich His pastimes:

“Nityananda was the very life and soul of Parameshvari Dasa. In his body Nityananda enjoyed various pastimes.” (CB, Antya 5.732)

“Parameshvara Dasa was wholly devoted to the lotus feet of Sri Nityananda. Anyone who simply remembers his name easily attains devotion to Krishna.” (CC, Adi 11.29)

Purushottama (Nagara) — in Vraja, the cowherd boy Dama (GGD 131). The “Charitamrita” counts him among Nityananda's devotees:

“From birth Purushottama Dasa was absorbed in service to the lotus feet of Sri Nityananda. All his childhood he plays games with Krishna.” (CC, Adi 11.39)

According to the “Chaitanya-bhagavata,” he is one of Nityananda's chief companions, unaware of his body, for Nityananda constantly acted through him:

“Nityananda Chandra Himself abode in the heart of Purushottama Dasa, and therefore in his body there was not a trace of external consciousness.” (CB, Antya 5.742)

Many of Nityananda's companions showed such powers: Purushottama, according to the “Gaudiya-vaishnava-abhidhana,” ate snake poison in trance.

Nityananda delivered Dhananjaya Pandita and, according to the “Chaitanya-bhagavata,” came to dwell in his heart forever (CB, Antya 5.733); in his shripata, Shitala-grama, the Deities of Nitai-Gauranga are served to this day. And on returning from Vrindavana, by one biography, he installed Deities — Gopinatha, Nitai-Gaura and a Damodara shila — in the village of Jalandi-grama. Kala (Kaliya) Krishnadasa, also one of the twelve gopalas, is one of Nityananda's chief devotees:

“One of the outstanding great Vaishnavas was Kala Krishnadasa. He wished to know nothing but the feet of Sri Nityananda.” (CC, Adi 11.37)

He must not be confused with the brahmana Krishnadasa, the Lord's servant in the South (see above): though the “Charitamrita” calls that one, too, Kala Krishnadasa, they are different persons, as Srila Bhaktisiddhanta distinguishes them (see note 38). Kamalakara Pippalai, one of the twelve gopalas (Mahabala, GGD 128; “Vaishnavachara-darpana”), is counted among Nityananda's branches. Mahesha Pandita is considered a branch of both Nityananda and Chaitanya; like all Nityananda's companions he was generous and devoted to saving the fallen, and danced in ecstasy like a madman; he was an especially close friend of Nityananda and, according to the “Chaitanya-bhagavata,” especially dear to Him; he was also in Khardaha when Narottama came there (BR 8.220). Jagadisha Pandita, too, is considered a branch of both Nityananda and Chaitanya: Nityananda, like Mahaprabhu, was won over by

his devotion and considered him one of His intimates, and for Jagadisha Nityananda was life and soul; he who served Jagannatha and Gaura-Gopala is called “a dear companion of Nityananda.” Drawn by the parental love of Jagadisha and his wife, Gauranga and Nityananda twice came to his shripata at Yashada, sang sankirtana there and held festivals.

To the singing of the three Ghosha brothers — Govinda, Madhava and Vasudeva — Nityananda danced:

“The three brothers — Madhava, Vasudeva and Govinda — sang while Lord Nityananda danced.” (CB, Antya 5.259)

“Three brothers — Govinda, Madhava and Vasudeva. When they sang kirtana with self-forgetfulness, Sri Chaitanya and Nityananda danced.” (CC, Adi 10.115)

Madhava Ghosha was especially dear to Nityananda; when the three brothers sang, Nityananda Himself danced in great ecstasy.

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta counts Gadadhara Dasa among the followers of both Gaura and Nityananda: as a follower of Gaura he is in the conjugal mood, as a follower of Nityananda in pure service; but his friendship is not the mood of a cowherd boy, but service in the spirit of madhurya (Anubhashya to CC, Adi 10.53). According to the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” (154–155), in him are the radiance of Radha (Chandrakanti) and Purnananda, the beloved companion of Balarama; he is not one of the gopalas who served Nityananda in sakhya-rasa. Speaking with the kazi of Eriyadaha, Gadadhara Dasa declared that Gaura and Nityananda had descended to save people with the nectar of Hari's name.

Counted in Nityananda's branch are also Nandana — the brother of Ganga Dasa and Vishnu Dasa, who composed verses and songs (by the “Gaudiya-vaishnava-abhidhana,” a different person from Nandana Acharya), — and those whom the “Charitamrita” names thus:

“Kamsari Sena, Ramasena, Ramachandra Kaviraja, and also the three physicians — Govinda, Shriranga and Mukunda.” (CC, Adi 11.51)

And Narottama from childhood meditated on the qualities of Chaitanya and Nityananda and prayed to Them; Shyamananda loved to hear of the glory of Gauranga and Nityananda. And Advaita's son Achyutananda, in the words of one biography, was “dear to Nityananda as life.”

Vrindavana Dasa Thakura, author of the “Chaitanya-bhagavata,” is called a disciple of Nityananda[59]; he himself called himself Nityananda's last servant.

“Having received the greatest mercy of Sri Nityananda, Srila Vrindavana Dasa Thakura beautifully described the pastimes of Sri Chaitanya, becoming like the original Vyasa.” (CC, Antya 20.82)

Whoever reads his book, says the “Charitamrita,” knows the glory of Chaitanya and Nitai. His Deities of Gaura-Nitai are worshipped to this day at Mamgachhi.

More than once Vrindavana Dasa repeats that he is ready to “put his foot on the head” of a blasphemer of Nityananda:

“I shall break the head of the wretched sinner who disregards the glory of Lord Nityananda and dares to criticise Him.” (CB, Adi 9.225)

Fools blame him for this and themselves fall into vaishnava-aparadha. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati in the “Gaudiya-bhashya” to this verse explains: in these words is the compassion of Nityananda's servant, the highest guru, even for blasphemers; the dust of his feet, falling on their heads, will destroy their sins. This is an example for the preacher: even in threatening, he wishes good[60].

From the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (it was also called the “Chaitanya-mangala”) Krishnadasa Kaviraja learned of the wonders of Chaitanya and Nityananda (CC, Adi 8.33–36). Srila Bhaktisiddhanta explains: Vrindavana Dasa, absorbed in describing the deeds of Nityananda, left out many events of his plan, and the Vaishnavas of Vrindavana asked Krishnadasa to describe them.

Krishnadasa Kaviraja himself was born in Jhamatpur; there his Deities of Gaura-Nitai are worshipped to this day, and in the courtyard of his house stands a small temple with the footprints of Nityananda. By local tradition, it was here that Krishnadasa received diksha from Nityananda[61]. His brother — by the “Gaudiya-vaishnava-abhidhana,” Shyama Dasa Kaviraja — believed in Chaitanya but not in Nityananda. When Minaketana Ramadasa came to Jhamatpur, shouting the name of Nityananda and filling the devotees' hearts with ecstasy, the pujari Gunarnava Mishra, who did not believe in Nityananda, did not rise to greet His disciple, and Minaketana called him a second Romaharshana:

“‘This is a second Romaharshana-suta, who on seeing Sri Balarama did not rise to offer Him his respects.’” (CC, Adi 5.170)

From this one sees how dear Minaketana is to Nityananda. Krishnadasa's brother quarrelled with Ramadasa; the latter in anger broke his flute and left — and this brought the brother ruin[62]. Krishnadasa took Ramadasa's side and rebuked his brother:

“‘These two Brothers (Sri Chaitanya and Nityananda) form one body. They are one and indivisible. And you will fall, because you have no faith in Nityananda.” (CC, Adi 5.175)

“If you believe in one and are disrespectful to the other, your logic is just like accepting only one half of a hen (the one that lays eggs).” (CC, Adi 5.176)

“Better to be an atheist and reject both Brothers than to be a hypocrite — to believe in one and not acknowledge the other.’” (CC, Adi 5.177)

Pleased, Nityananda appeared to Krishnadasa in a dream:

“Lord Sri Nityananda-Balarama appeared to me in a dream in the village of Jhamatpur, which lies near Naihati.” (CC, Adi 5.181)

“Krishnadasa, do not fear, go to Vrindavana — there you will attain everything,” said Nitai, and with a wave of His hand showed him the way; He granted him the vision of Himself, the right to live in Vrindavana and service at the feet of Radha-Krishna. To accept Chaitanya without Nityananda or Nityananda without Chaitanya is hostile to bhakti; and the Lord values even a small attachment: Krishnadasa merely took the side of Nityananda's companion — and received His blessing. Not for nothing does he begin every chapter of the “Charitamrita” by invoking Mahaprabhu and His companions — Nityananda and Advaita.

The “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” (67–68) says that the brothers Nishatha and Ulmuka entered Virachandra for a purpose, and that Minaketana Ramadasa is “another Sankarshana, the original vyuha”[63]. As Nityananda is an avadhuta, so is His follower Minaketana; Srila Bhaktisiddhanta explains: a disciple of Nityananda is an eternally perfect maha-bhagavata, a paramahamsa beyond varnashrama.

The Disappearance

Neither the date, nor the place, nor the circumstances of Nityananda's departure are named by the biographies on which this article rests. All that is known is that when Shrinivasa was returning from Puri to Bengal (Gadadhara Pandita was by then no longer in this world), Advaita and Nityananda had already withdrawn Themselves; hearing this on the way, he fell down on the road and again resolved to give up his body, but that same night both Prabhus out of causeless mercy appeared to him in a dream, consoled him and dissuaded him.

Of the order of the departures one can speak only on the word of two biographies, and even then without dates. By one, Vrindavana Dasa was born four years after the Lord's sannyasa, at Mahaprabhu's departure he was barely twenty, and soon after that he received initiation from Nityananda, and later went with Jahnava to Kheturi. The other remarks: since Vrindavana Dasa called himself Nityananda's last servant, Nityananda remained in His manifest pastimes only a short time after that initiation. From both accounts it follows that Nityananda withdrew Himself after Mahaprabhu; when exactly, none of the books says.

A tradition recorded in later works (by Jayananda and in the “Nityananda-vamsha-vistara”) says that Nityananda entered Bankimdeva in Ekachakra — and the sevaits of Bankim-raya tell the same (see above, “Bankim-raya and the Memorial Places of Ekachakra”). Be that as it may, His pastimes did not cease: at the festival in Kheturi (BR 10) Gauranga Himself appeared in the kirtana with Nityananda and all the eternal associates, and the devotees saw Nityananda and Advaita overwhelmed with ecstasy. And Raghunandana, consoling Shrinivasa before his own departure, quoted verses from the “Sri Krishna-bhajanamrita” of Narahari Sarakara (3–4): when Krishna Chaitanya and His companion Nityananda conclude Their appearance, the Vaishnavas of the Kali-yuga will grow ever more anxious and full of doubts — a hard time is drawing near; and then he blessed Shrinivasa to preach.

Identifications

According to the “Bhakti-ratnakara,” Hadai Pandita and Padmavati are in Krishna's lila Vasudeva and Rohini (see above). Balarama's wives, Varuni and Revati, according to the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” (65), became Vasudha and Jahnava; both are daughters of Surya Dasa, who was formerly Kakudmi, the father of Revati[52]. Ananga-manjari, the younger sister of Radha, daughter of Vrishabhanu, the same book (66) connects with both: “Some in the age of Kali declare Ananga-manjari to be Sri Vasudha Devi, and some call Jahnavi Ananga-manjari,” — and the saints, by the former rule of the distinction of manifestations, accept both as true. The biographies speak only of Jahnava as Ananga-manjari: the possessor of energy is not different from His energy. One of them holds this view; another considers acceptable both it and the identification with Revati, for several personalities can be united in the Lord's associates.

Virachandra, according to the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” (67), is Kshirodakashayi Vishnu, an expansion (vyuha) of Sankarshana, not different from Chaitanya, and Nishatha and Ulmuka entered him for a purpose (68; see above); by one biography, he is eternally known by this name and eternally manifest in Goloka; by another view, he is Aniruddha, who appeared as Nityananda's son. Ganga Devi, Nityananda's daughter, is an incarnation of the river Ganga, and her husband Madhavacharya an incarnation of King Shantanu, Ganga's husband in the “Mahabharata” (GGD 69).

The Tattva of Nityananda

Krishna is svayam-rupa, the original form of God; Baladeva is svayam-prakasha, the first manifestation of that same form, the full expansion of Krishna (so explains Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati on CC, Adi 1.14). The “Charitamrita” says:

“Sri Krishna is the original Bhagavan, the source of all manifestations of God, and Sri Balarama is His second body.” (CC, Adi 5.4)

“Their essence is one; the difference is only in form. Sri Balarama is the first expansion of Krishna's body. He assists Krishna in all His pastimes.” (CC, Adi 5.5)

Krishna's first expansion is mula-Sankarshana Balarama, the original father of all; He it is who came with Lord Chaitanya as Nityananda. Nityananda is baladeva-tattva, mula-Sankarshana, the cause of

Maha-Sankarshana in Vaikuntha and the source of the three purusha-avataras: Karanodakashayi, Garbhodakashayi and Kshirodakashayi Vishnu. Mula-Sankarshana is the eternally worshipped deity of Shiva. Ananta-Shesha, who holds up the earth, is so closely bound to Him that Nityananda is called Ananta Himself[64].

Svarupa Damodara, the "second self" of Sri Gaurasundara, glorified Nityananda in five verses of his "Kadcha," which Krishnadasa Kaviraja quotes at the beginning of the "Charitamrita" (CC, Adi 1.7–11):

"May Lord Sri Nityananda-Balarama become my eternal shelter. For Maha-Sankarshana, Shesha-Naga and also the three Purusha-avataras (Karanodakashayi Vishnu, Garbhodakashayi Vishnu and Kshirodakashayi Vishnu) are His full or partial divine manifestations." (CC, Adi 1.7)

The sense of these verses is this. In Vaikuntha, beyond maya, in the quaternity Vasudeva — Sankarshana — Pradyumna — Aniruddha, He is present as Sankarshana. His portion is Karanabdhishayi, the first purusha-avatara, master of maya and shelter of the universes; the portion of the portion is Garbhodakashayi, from the lotus of whose navel Brahma is born; the portion of the portion of the portion is Kshirodakashayi, the Paramatma of all, Vishnu the maintainer; His kala is Ananta, who holds up the earth.

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati unfolds the same in more detail. From Baladeva, Sankarshana — the form of Nityananda — abides in Mahavaikuntha. By His glance on the waters of the Karana He manifests the lila of Maha-Vishnu; rising in the waters of the Garbha, the lila of the collective (samashti) Vishnu; by His glance on the Milk Ocean, the lila of the individual (vyashti) Vishnu, caring for the welfare of living beings. As Shesha He serves Krishna in ten forms — as bed, seat and so on (cf. CC, Adi 5.10). From His form abiding in the waters of the Karana are manifested Goloka-Vrindavana, Vaikuntha, the countless anu-chaitanyas, the minute living beings of the jiva-shakti, and the universe with its fourteen worlds[65]; from Him, too, Advaita, the inner controller and material cause of the world; from Him the naimittika-avataras — Rama, Nrisimha and others — eternally appear. And when Govinda, the cause of all causes, manifested the magnanimous lila of Gaura and began to give out Krishna-prema, Baladeva manifested His form as Nityananda to serve this lila of the bestowal of love. The living beings eternally dependent on Him are known as Gaura's associates — gaura-parshadas.

Nityananda is vishnu-tattva and therefore the Lord of all shaktis; and yet He is a faithful servant, showing the way to Krishna's hladini, the energy of bliss: He is the sandhini-shaktimad-vigraha, the bearer of the energy of being. At His feet is all vishnu-tattva; though He is not different from it and stands within its hierarchy, He is the servant of Gauranga. Gaurangasundara is Mahaprabhu, and Nityananda is His vibhu, vaibhava-prakasha; He is shaktiman-tattva, not shakti-tattva. The "Charitamrita" says it briefly:

"One of Them is Mahaprabhu, and the other two are Prabhus. These two Prabhus serve the lotus feet of Mahaprabhu." (CC, Adi 7.14)

Nityananda is the original cause of Maha-Vishnu and vishaya-tattva — the One who is served; He manifested the rasa-lila with the gopis, who serve Him as ashraya. In the language of the alankara-shastra the one served is called vishaya, the one serving ashraya[66]. He is the master of prakriti, no part of Him is material, His body is eternally manifest from a supernatural substance; He is shaktiman, vishnu-tattva, and Vasudha and Jahnava Thakurani are His transcendental shaktis. For the aprakrita Vishnu and His associates there is no difference between the body and the possessor of the body — maya does not divide them; His appearance in the world is not painful and not caused by karma, as ours is, and His pastimes are eternally manifest in Goloka. Without aprakrita vision this cannot be understood; by the guru's mercy, having gained transcendental knowledge, one sees it all clearly, while those who judge in a worldly way cannot see Nityananda — the dance of the material

senses never pleases Him. Nityananda's pastimes are eternal, eternal too is the appearance of Virabhadra; in them there is not even a scent of matter.

Accepting the mood of a devotee, Baladeva appears as the bhakta-svarupa — Nityananda; though He is Bhagavat-tattva, He behaves as a devotee. When Krishna comes as Sri Krishna Chaitanya, taking the mood and colour of Radha, His eternal associates come with Him; so too Baladeva, the first expansion (prakasha) of Krishna, appears in Ekachakra as Nityananda to adorn the pastimes of Mahaprabhu, and He has His own circle of intimates who descend to help Him. In the Pancha-tattva Nityananda is the bhakta-svarupa, the form of a devotee; Gauranga is the bhakta-rupa, Advaita the bhakta-avatara; these three are prabhu-tattva, vishnu-tattva, and therefore tulasi leaves are offered at Their feet. The one Truth, teaches Srila Bhaktisiddhanta, manifests five forms for the tasting of different rasas, but ontologically they are not different from one another:

“I offer obeisances to the Supreme Lord Krishna in His five aspects, known as the Pancha-tattva: I fall prostrate before Sri Gauranga, who appeared as His own devotee, wishing to taste His own sweetness. Then I bow to the lotus feet of His elder brother Sri Nityananda, the original Guru. …” (CC, Adi 1.14)

Every form of vishnu-tattva possesses three energies — Shri, Bhu and Nila (Lila); Nityananda, too, possesses them.

Mahaprabhu is the main trunk and the gardener of the tree of devotion, and Advaita and Nityananda are the two trunks into which it divides:

“Above, the trunk divides into two great branches. One branch is Sri Advaita, and the other branch is Nityananda.” (CC, Adi 9.21)

Sri Chaitanya is the body of the movement of bhakti, Advaita and Nityananda its limbs; all three descended together with Srivasa and others to preach hari-bhakti. The eleventh chapter of the Adi-lila, on Nityananda's branches, Krishnadasa opens with a verse in which Nityananda is the “moon among avadhutas,” the highest branch of the eternal tree of love:

“The Avadhuta Sri Nityananda Prabhu is the continuation of the lofty trunk of the unfading tree of Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu, which embodies eternal love for Sri Krishna. I offer obeisances to all the devotees, who are like the twigs of this main branch.” (CC, Adi 11.4)

From this branch grow branches and sub-branches, and the greatest of them after Him is Virabhadra.

Among all the Lord's eternal associates Nityananda is the first:

“Sri Nityananda Avadhuta is the chief among all the eternal associates of Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu. In the bliss of prema He serves Sri Chaitanya as a servant, and this intoxication of love makes Him a madman.” (CC, Adi 6.47)

Sri Chaitanya is glorified both as “the life of Nityananda” and as “the life of Gadadhara” (“Chaitanya-bhagavata”, Madhya 9.3: “Glory to Him, the very life of Nityananda and Gadadhara!”). Srila Bhaktisiddhanta explains: devotees who wish to worship Radha-Govinda in madhura-rasa take shelter of Gadadhara; those not so inclined take shelter of Nityananda and serve with pure devotion in His mood. And without Advaita's mercy, sings Narottama Dasa (“dayā karo sītāpati…”), one attains the service of neither Chaitanya nor Nityananda.

Deities of Gaura-Nitai and Later Worship

Nityananda is worshipped together with Gaura in many temples. In the royal palace of Puri the Deities of Gaura-Nityananda and Gaura-Gadadhara are honoured; in the house of Kashi Mishra (Radha-kanta-matha), in the time of Gopala Guru (1538–1548), Deities of Gauranga and Nityananda

were installed. Deities of Nitai-Gauranga together with Advaita stand in the Madana-Mohana temple in Ramakeli, Gaura-Nityananda in the temple at Chakra-tirtha on Govardhana; Narottama brought to Kheturi the Deities of Sri Gauranga-Nityananda[67]. In the shripata of Mahesha Pandita the Deities of Gaura-Nityananda are served, together with Gopinatha, Madana-Mohana, Radha-Govinda and a shalagrama-shila; in Ambika Jahnava-mata, on the way to Kheturi, cooked with her own hands the offering for Gauridasa's Deities of Gaura-Nityananda.

The name of Nitai never leaves the lips of His followers. Vamshi sang in longing: “Will Nimai and Nitai ever dance together again?” Shyamananda's disciples — the yogi Damodara, Rasika Murari — sang the names of Nitai-Chaitanya, and Shyamananda himself “offered” Rasika to Chaitanya and Nityananda. Narottama, Shrinivasa, Shyamananda, Rasikananda, Gangamata, Mahidhara Sharma and others preached “the message of Gaura-Nityananda” and sang Their names; Gadadhara Dasa and Abhirama lived in separation from Gaura-Nityananda, and Lokanatha grieved that he was unable to serve Gaura-Nityananda. Jagannatha Dasa Babaji sang: “What a Name Nitai has brought! He has brought it to market and gives it for the price of faith.” Vamshi Dasa Babaji carried Deities of Nitai-Gaura (and of Radha-Govinda) in a little bag and answered seekers: “Worship Nitai — and you will attain Gaura”; outside the worship of Gaura-Nitai there is no joy in this world. (Tobacco, by his custom, he offered only to Radha-Govinda, not to Nitai-Gauranga.)

In the Gaudiya Math from 1926 a three-day nama-yajna was held every year in honour of Nityananda's appearance, and in 1933 Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati celebrated His appearance day in Mayapur. When in 1925 Bhaktisiddhanta's parikrama was attacked, a newspaper compared it with Jagai and Madhai's attempt to wound Nityananda Avadhuta. Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami is called “nityanandavesha” — empowered by Shripada Nityananda Prabhu. One of the biographies opens with a picture of “Sri Nityananda Prabhu” and closes with the line “Krishna Chaitanya, Prabhu Nityananda, Advaita, Gadadhara, Srivasa.”

Significance

Nityananda is a mercy to which anyone may turn. Madhava is pleased by bhakti alone, not by birth, learning or wealth: “what good conduct had the hunter, what age had Dhruva…” (“Padyavali,” 8). Krishna grants good even to those who remember Him with hostility: even Putana received the position of a nurse (“Bhagavatam,” 3.2.23). But the living beings of the age of Kali cannot imitate hostile “service”: Shishupala and Dantavakra were unremitting in enmity, while Vena had not even such concentration — only sin resulted; therefore the mahajanas teach only favourable service.

The fallen one fears even the “Bhakta-vatsala,” the One who loves His devotees: “remembering Your name ‘Friend of the humble’…” (“Padyavali,” 64). This fear is removed by Gaura's devotees: whoever opens his heart at the feet of Nityananda, Him He will save — and this is a plain fact, not praise for its own sake (arthavada).

Krishnadasa Kaviraja sums up all that Nityananda gave him:

“Glory to Sri Nityananda-Balarama, by whose mercy I have attained the shelter of Vrindavana-dhama.” (CC, Adi 5.200)

“May Sri Nityananda be glorified forever! By His causeless mercy I have attained the shelter of Sri Rupa and Sanatana Gosvami.” (CC, Adi 5.201)

“All glory to the lotus feet of Sri Nityananda! By His mercy I have attained connection with the divine Couple, Sri Sri Radha-Govinda.” (CC, Adi 5.204)

After him come Narottama Dasa Thakura and Bhaktivinoda Thakura. Narottama sings of Nitai's lotus feet and prays: “When will Nityananda be merciful to me and free me from birth and death? By His mercy one gives up worldly enjoyment, purifies the mind and reaches Vrindavana” (“āra kabe nitāi-cānda…”); Bhaktivinoda sings of Nitai and the marketplace of the holy name. Following these mahajanas, the author of one biography, on the day of Nityananda's appearance, prays at the feet of His associates for a drop of love for Nityananda and proclaims His victory: without Nitai one cannot attain Radha-Krishna.

1. “Vishvambhara” (“He who sustains the universe”) is usually the name of Mahaprabhu Himself; here it stands in the list of Nityananda's names. The name “Gaudeshvara” might be taken for a misprint of “Gaureshvara” (“the Lord of Gaura”), but Vrindavana Dasa calls Him so at the very beginning of the account of His appearance as well: Ekachaka is the village “where Gaudeshvara [appeared],” the Lord of the Gaudiya Vaishnavas (CB, Adi 9.5).

2. One of the biographies, speaking of Gangadasa Pandita, says that Nityananda appeared in Rarh, and Gangadasa, Murari and Mukunda elsewhere. The “Charitamrita” (Adi 13.61) names Radha-desha as the birthplace of all four.

3. In a short summary of the same chapter of the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” the voice proclaims otherwise: “Soon I shall appear in Mathura and Gokula to lighten the burden of the Earth.”

4. So in the text of the chapter itself; in its short summary it is Nityananda in the role of Rama Himself who crushes Parashurama's pride.

5. One biography retells it differently: Hadai Pandita took his son in his arms and himself asked where He had learned this; in the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Adi 9.91–92) the father embraces his son, and it is the people who ask.

6. One of the biographies calls Nityananda the eldest son of Hadai and Padmavati, but gives no names of their other children.

7. Only one biography tells of the sannyasi who led Nityananda away from home; the others say only that at twelve He set out for the holy places.

8. So in the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Adi 9.100–101): twelve years at home and twenty years of wandering. According to other biographies (and to the short summary prefixed to the chapter in the edition of the “Bhagavata”), He wandered “until He was twenty years old” and met Mahaprabhu in Navadvipa in the twentieth year of His life; one biography, retelling this summary, adds that the chapter “ends with an explanation of Nityananda's renunciation” — the summary itself says otherwise: at the end of the chapter it is explained why Nityananda had not yet begun preaching the holy name. Yet another biography remarks in passing, as something well known, that Nityananda was twelve years older than Mahaprabhu; by the periods of the “Bhagavata,” at the time of His meeting with the Lord after the Lord's return from Gaya Nityananda must have been over thirty.

9. The order of places here is that of the chapter's text (CB, Adi 9). One biography gives the same route as a single list; it lacks the Buddhist monastery, Karttikeya and Arya-Dvaipayani, and names Madura twice. The reading “Uttara-Yamuna” differs between accounts; Dvaipayani (the “island” Arya, that is, Parvati, CB, Adi 9.150) has become in one of them “the venerable consort of Dvaipayana.”

10. So according to the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (a holy place on the western coast) and one of the biographies; according to another, in South India; the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” does not name the region.

11. In the biographies these words are given to Nityananda: nowhere had He seen such prema — Madhavendra falls senseless at the mere sight of a cloud. In the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” it is Madhavendra who speaks of the unseen love (Adi 9.182), and the swoon at the sight of a cloud is told by the author himself (9.175).

12. So according to the “Chaitanya-bhagavata.” In one retelling, on the contrary, Nityananda began to describe Madhavendra's glory, while he embraced Him.

13. The “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Adi 9.179) speaks of a few days; one account says “many days.”

14. According to the biographies, it was Madhavendra who laughed, wept and cried out like one intoxicated; in the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Adi 9.176) — both of them.

15. Some consider Nityananda a disciple of Madhavendra Puri (so too Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati: Madhavendra's chief disciples were Ishvara Puri, Nityananda and Advaita); others a disciple of Lakshmipati Tirtha, and hence Madhavendra's godbrother; the “Prema-vilasa” names Ishvara Puri as His guru.

16. Two biographies speak of the chakra on the temple; the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Adi 9.198) speaks of the flag (dhvaja) crowning the temple.

17. One biography even says, “while He lived in Vrindavana, Gaurasundara appeared in Navadvipa.” This must be understood as “revealed Himself” — after His return from Gaya: on the day of Gaura's birth Nityananda, as told above, was in Ekachakra.

18. According to one biography, Nityananda, wandering through India in search of Krishna, heard in Vrindavana that Krishna had appeared in Navadvipa; according to another, He came to know it in His heart. He Himself, as He told the Lord at their meeting, had heard it from great Vaishnavas (see below).

19. So according to most biographies. One of them, in its account of Sadashiva Pandita, calls Sadashiva's house Nityananda's first dwelling in Navadvipa; the "Charitamrita" says this without the word "first": "The twelfth branch is Sadashiva Pandita, possessed by the desire to serve the lotus feet of Sri Chaitanya. Nityananda Himself lived in his house in Navadvipa" (CC, Adi 10.34); and the "Chaitanya-bhagavata" calls Sadashiva the one "in whose house Nityananda formerly lived" (CB, Antya 8.19).

20. One biography says "with a plough and a mace on his shoulders"; in the "Chaitanya-bhagavata" (Madhya 3.143) it is an enormous pole at his shoulder, and our edition explains that this is Baladeva's club or plough.

21. Baladeva's "wine" — varuni — is in His lila no worldly intoxicant; Srivasa's answer itself discloses the meaning: what is meant is the taste of Hari-rasa, which the Lord alone gives.

22. According to one biography, Murari Gupta explained the meaning of the dream to the Vaishnavas; in the "Chaitanya-bhagavata" (Madhya 3.157–158) the Lord Himself explains it.

23. According to one account, Mahaprabhu knew at once that Nityananda was at Nandana's and went there with the devotees — without any search. The "Chaitanya-mangala" (Madhya 4) also says that devotees were sent to look for Nityananda.

24. According to the "Chaitanya-mangala" (Madhya 4), the Lord, meeting Nityananda in Nandana Acharya's house, explained His glory — that by His mercy one obtains love for Krishna — and showed Him His six-armed, four-armed and two-armed forms. According to the "Chaitanya-bhagavata," the Lord showed Him the six-armed form at the Vyasa-puja (see below).

25. The biographies relate the revelations of that night differently: according to one, Mahaprabhu showed everyone that Nityananda is Baladeva; according to another — and so in the "Chaitanya-bhagavata" itself (Madhya 5.37–55) — He Himself entered the mood of Baladeva, revealing Nityananda's identity with Balarama, and then, crying "Nara, Nara!", disclosed that Advaita had brought Him down; according to a third, Gaurahari only hinted to Nityananda that He had descended for the sake of Advaita Acharya.

26. Srivasa's words are the measure of his faith, not a description of Nityananda's deeds: even in the most unthinkable case he would not have doubted Him. Cf. note 28.

27. According to one biography, the Lord blessed Srivasa on seeing his devotion to Nityananda after the Vyasa-puja; according to another, after the test described.

28. The behaviour of Nityananda the avadhuta — nakedness, a childlike mood, apparent recklessness — cannot be measured by a worldly yardstick. He is Baladeva Himself, not subject to maya, and acts only in prema; so teaches Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati. The acts of the highest, the uttama-adhikari, and still more of the Lord Himself, are not a model for imitation: one must not imitate them.

29. According to the "Chaitanya-mangala" (Madhya 5), this took place in Advaita Acharya's house, where Nityananda spent two days: Mahaprabhu "rescued" His kaupina and told the devotees to wear its shreds as an amulet (kavacha).

30. So in the "Chaitanya-bhagavata" (Madhya 20.14–17). One biography retells the dream the other way round: Nityananda-Balarama fans Mahaprabhu-Krishna with a chamara.

31. So in the "Chaitanya-bhagavata" (Madhya 13.173–182). According to one biography, Madhai threw the shard when Nityananda and Haridasa were returning together after preaching; according to another, Nityananda later went to the brothers alone and delivered them, without the episode of the shard and the chakra; He is the most merciful, who saved such sinners and gave them love of God. The deliverance of the brothers is also mentioned in the account of Pundarika Vidyanidhi.

32. The Lord and Nityananda accept food from a fallen man not because They approve his path (Gaura, hearing of the "ananda," cried "Vishnu! Vishnu!" and threw Himself into the Ganga), but out of a mercy that can bring even such a man to good. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati teaches that the acts of the highest adhikari are not measured by a worldly yardstick and are not imitated (cf. note 28).

33. One biography places this verse in the procession to the Kazi itself.

34. The "Charitamrita" names three: "The Lord was accompanied by Nityananda Prabhu, Chandrashekhara Acharya and Mukunda Datta. They performed all the necessary rites" (CC, Adi 17.273). One of the biographies adds Gadadhara and Brahmananda (according to the "Chaitanya-bhagavata," Madhya 28, this is Brahmananda Bharati).

35. According to the "Charitamrita," with the Lord went Nityananda, Mukunda Datta, Jagadananda and Damodara Pandita; according to the "Chaitanya-bhagavata," Nityananda, Gadadhara Pandita, Mukunda, Govinda and Brahmananda; in one biography, "Nityananda, Mukunda and others."

36. So according to the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Antya 2.202–204; in one retelling of this passage the danda is left “with Nityananda and Svarupa”). According to another biography, at Kamalapur Gaura went to Shiva Kapoteshvara and Himself left the danda with Nityananda. That Nityananda set the pieces floating down the river is told by only one of the biographies.

37. Another interpretation: Nityananda, non-different from Balarama, taught His followers to accept the tridanda — the sign of Vaishnava tridandi-sannyasa.

38. The “Charitamrita” (Madhya 10) also calls him Kala Krishnadasa, and some biographies therefore take him for Kala Krishnadasa of the twelve gopalas of Nityananda's branch. But these are different persons: Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati distinguishes them (Anubhashya on CC, Madhya 7.39), and so does one of the biographies (on Kala Krishnadasa of the gopalas see below).

39. Who sent Krishnadasa to Gauda the biographies tell differently. By one, Mahaprabhu Himself sent him to inform the Bengali Vaishnavas (in one place it is even said: together with Nityananda and others). By others, it was Nityananda who sent Krishnadasa to Navadvipa — with maha-prasada and news for Shachi. By a third account, when the Lord rejected Krishnadasa for his fall in the South, Nityananda, Damodara, Jagadananda and Mukunda, out of compassion for him, conferred and proposed sending him to Navadvipa, and the Lord agreed (CC, Madhya 10).

40. In one biography this cloth is called a loincloth; the bahirvasa, however, is the upper cloth.

41. The biographies name the companions differently: some — Abhirama (Ramadasa) and Gadadhara Dasa; others — Rama Dasa, Gadadhara Dasa, Krishnadasa Pandita, Parameshvari Dasa, Purandara Pandita, Raghunatha Vaidya “and others.” The “Charitamrita” in another place speaks of three: “By the direct order of Sri Chaitanya, Nityananda Prabhu went to Bengal together with three devotees. These three devotees were Ramadasa, Madhava and Vasudeva Ghosha. Govinda Ghosha, however, stayed with Sri Chaitanya and was extraordinarily glad of it” (CC, Adi 10.117–118).

42. The same source converts this year as 1534 of the Common Era; but the year 1434 of the Shaka era is 1512, so one of the two figures is wrong.

43. So according to two biographies; a third, in its account of Sundarananda, ascribes the miracle of the kadamba on the lemon tree to him (see below, “Disciples and Companions”).

44. Only one biography reports this, with a reference to the “Vijaya-khanda”; what this source is remains unclear.

45. One biography adds that Narottama saw Mahesha there; chronologically this is doubtful.

46. By one biography, Mahaprabhu came of His own accord, drawn by the festival and the dancing; by another, Nityananda by the power of meditation (dhyana-yoga) brought Gaura to Panihati and had Him accept the feast. Nityananda's words to Raghunatha (CC, Antya 6.139–140) say that the Lord came to taste the feast out of His mercy; by one retelling — invisibly to others.

47. The biographies relate the details of the dana-lila differently. By one, Nityananda watched the performance (it was played by Madhavananda Ghosha) and fell into deep trance; according to the “Charitamrita,” Nityananda Himself played in it; by another account, the drama “Dana-khanda” was staged by Madhava Ghosha with Nityananda and Gadadhara Dasa taking part; by a third, Nityananda danced to Madhavananda Ghosha's song of the dana-khanda-lila.

48. One biography places these words at the meeting in the garden; in the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Antya 6.124) they are heard by the brahmana who doubted Nityananda (see above).

49. All three versions of the tradition are given by one and the same biography, in different places, without reconciling them.

50. The first by one biography, the second by another.

51. Where and in whose house the wedding was held the biographies tell differently. By one, the adhivasa was in the house of Krishnadasa Sarakhela in Shaligrama, while further on the same biography names Shantipur as the place of the wedding. By another, the preparations took place in Boroganchhi, in the house of Krishnadasa, son of Harihora, who persuaded Nityananda to come there; in the same place this Krishnadasa is called Surya Dasa's brother — evidently two Krishnadasas have been confused: the son of Harihora and Krishnadasa Sarakhela.

52. Which daughter was Revati and which Varuni is not clearly said, and the order of the names in one biography shifts: according to the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” (65) Balarama's wives Varuni and Revati became Vasudha and Jahnava; in the dream Surya Dasa sees them “as Revati and Varuni,” in waking “as Varuni and Revati.” On Ananga-manjari (Vasudha or Jahnava) see below, “Identifications.”

53. By one biography, after the wedding Nityananda remained in Shaligrama and then came with His wives to Shachi; by another, at Shachi's request He lived in Navadvipa, then with Uddharana in Saptagrama, and finally settled for good in Khardaha. Here these accounts are combined into one.

54. Nityananda's marriage is His lila, arranged by His own energy (yogamaya), not a bond brought about by karma: Vasudha and Jahnava are His transcendental shaktis, and these pastimes are eternal (see below, “The Tattva of Nityananda”). So teaches Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati; they must not be measured by a worldly measure (cf. note 28).

55. Two lists of Jahnava's companions from different biographies are combined here. In one of them Krishna Mishra is called “her uncle”; on what this rests is not said.

56. Kanu Thakura was born on the day of the Ratha-yatra: by one biography, in the year 1450 of the Shaka era; by another, which cites his descendants, in 1457 Shaka (942 of the Bengali era), on a Thursday, on the second tithi of the bright half of Ashadha. Why Nityananda came for the boy only twelve years after his mother's departure, this second biography does not explain. The “Charitamrita” calls Kanu Thakura the son of Purushottama Dasa (CC, Adi 11.40).

57. By one biography, Shrimati and Narayani were sisters, daughters of Yadunandana; by two others, Narayani was the adopted daughter of Yadunatha (Yadunandana) Acharya and Vidyunmala.

58. By another tradition, Gauridasa asked Mahaprabhu to stay with him forever, and the Lord revealed that His form and Nityananda's were hidden in a neem tree nearby; Gauridasa had Gaura-Nitai carved from it, and, it is said, Nityananda Himself was present at the carving. When They were about to leave, the Lord said: “Nityananda and I are directly present in these forms; choose — either the Deities go, or We.” Gauridasa chose that the “real” Gaura-Nitai should stay and the Deities might go — for the name, the Deity and the Lord Himself are one; how this choice ended is not clear in the retelling.

59. By one biography, Vrindavana Dasa received initiation from Nityananda; by another, he received Nityananda's abundant blessings and is therefore considered His disciple.

60. In one retelling of the same chapter the words of Vrindavana Dasa run: “If, after all he has heard, there is a sinner who does not value Him or who blasphemes Him — I strike his face with my left foot.”

61. According to the “Prema-vilasa,” Krishnadasa Kaviraja received diksha from Raghunatha Dasa Gosvami.

62. One and the same biography tells this differently in two places: in one, Gunarnava made no reply to the rebuke and the brother was “doomed to ruin”; in the other, Gunarnava was glad of the rebuke and the brother was doomed to lose all his devotion. According to the “Charitamrita,” the brother then lost all hope in spiritual life (CC, Adi 5.178).

63. One biography reads this verse differently: Nishatha and Ulmuka entered Nityananda's expansions — Minaketana and Rama; and since, according to the “Charitamrita” and the “Bhakti-ratnakara,” Minaketana Ramadasa is one person, perhaps both were united in him. Here the verse is given according to the Sanskrit and our translation of the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika.”

64. So in the retelling of the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Adi 9): Nityananda is “Ananta-deva Himself, who appeared by the will of Gaura-Krishna”; and one of the biographies calls Him Lord Shesha Himself. But according to the verses of Svarupa Damodara (see below), Ananta, who holds up the earth, is His kala, a portion. Only the words differ: Ananta is His own manifestation.

65. “Manifested” does not mean “created”: Goloka and Vaikuntha are eternal abodes; they are not made. Baladeva-Sankarshana is the bearer of sandhini, the energy of being (see below), and therefore He is the eternal ground through which the spiritual abodes manifest themselves; so teaches Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati. Only the material universe is created — through the purusha-avataras.

66. Of Balarama's rasa-lila with the gopis of Vraja the “Srimad-Bhagavatam” speaks (10.65). It is a pastime of His internal energy: the gopis — ashraya — serve Him, the vishaya, for His joy, and in this pastime there is no worldly lust, just as there is none in Krishna's rasa-lila.

67. On the adjoining page of the same biography the Deities brought by Narottama to Kheturi are called Gauranga and Vishnupriya.